

Husband held for dowry harassment after wife’s death in Lodhi Colony area

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Arastu Sikka, the husband of 28-year-old Akriti, who was found dead near an NDMC residential complex in Delhi's Lodhi Colony on Saturday evening, has been arrested. The husband was arrested on charges of dowry harassment, police confirmed on Monday.

The victim's mother's complaint to police revealed that Akriti had told her on June 29, five days before her death, that her husband might kill her. Akriti, a resident of Pushp Vihar who worked as a sales executive at a private company in Chhatarpur, had been married to Sikka for exactly 72 days when she died. She had married on April 24 this year.

On Saturday, July 5, she had gone to work, hosted a party for her colleagues, and then fallen silent. Her phone was switched off. Her family learned of her death around 10 pm when a police officer from Lodhi Colony police station answered Akriti's phone and asked them to come to the station.

She was found critically injured outside B-Block of the NDMC flats at Palika Kunj. She was rushed to AIIMS, where doctors declared her brought dead. Police believe she fell from the third floor. CCTV footage from the complex is being examined



to determine whether she arrived alone and what happened before the fall.

Injuries were found on her left arm and thigh, and investigators are trying to establish whether these preceded the fall or resulted from it.

A postmortem examination is in progress.

In her complaint to police, Akriti's mother, Anu Say Sutar, said the harassment began almost immediately after the wedding. The couple had dated for two years before marrying. Before the marriage, Akriti had made clear to her in-laws that she would continue working because her father was dead and she needed to financially support her younger brother and mother. The family had agreed. After the marriage, the agreement was disregarded entirely.

The mother alleged that Akriti was told to quit her job, and when she refused, all household chores were foisted on her to force the issue. She was allegedly

abused for calling her mother or visiting her maternal home. On June 17, Akriti told her mother on a call that Arastu had beaten her with a belt because her phone was on silent and she had missed his call. He had accused her of keeping the phone silent to hide illicit relationships, the complaint stated.

The flashpoint over money was specific and recurring. Akriti was the family's primary earner after her father's death five years ago. She wanted to send ₹5,000 every month to her mother. This became a source of repeated conflict. The family alleged her husband had demanded she hand over her entire salary. Separately, her mother and uncle alleged that the husband and his relatives had demanded ₹20 lakh as dowry after the marriage, in addition to the ₹7 to 8 lakh the family had already spent on the wedding.

On June 29, Akriti called her mother and said she

feared Arastu might kill her.

On the same day, he allegedly assaulted her over a food dispute. She went to the house of Augustika, Arastu's sister and Akriti's childhood friend, through whom the couple had met, to discuss the situation. Arastu followed her there and attempted to assault her again before being calmed down. A reconciliation was arranged, and Akriti returned to her husband's home.

On July 3, Akriti's mother called Arastu's father, asking him to intervene. This allegedly angered Arastu, who then threatened to get Akriti's brother fired from his job and beaten up. Augustika also called the mother and told her not to interfere, allegedly saying that Akriti had been brought to their home to cook and do housework and that no job-related agreement was official.

On the morning of July 5, Akriti called her mother and said she was leaving for work. Her phone went off after that. She did not come home. Police have confirmed the arrest of Arastu Sikka.

Since the death occurred within seven years of marriage, mandatory inquest proceedings have been initiated, and the SDM has been informed. All possible angles, including the family's allegations of murder, are under investigation.

Police special cell busts Pakistan-backed terror modules linked to Shahzad Bhatti network; 6 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a counter-terrorism operation, the Delhi Police Special Cell broke up two suspected Pakistan-backed groups connected to the Shahzad Bhatti network and arrested six people. Police say the suspects were planning a terror attack in Delhi and were involved in smuggling illegal weapons across the country.

According to police, one group was supposed to attack a key site or police building in Delhi using petrol bombs. The other group focused on moving advanced firearms that were reportedly smuggled from Pakistan into India using drones. This operation highlights the ongoing risk posed by cross-border terrorist networks targeting the capital. capital.

These arrests come at a time when security agencies are on high alert for groups that mix local recruits with handlers based in Pakistan.

Special Cell sources say the operation followed ongoing intelligence work and technical surveillance. Police raided several locations and arrested six people believed to be part of two connected groups.

Early questioning suggests the suspects were getting instructions from handlers in Pakistan linked to Shahzad Bhatti, who is suspected of running terror and crime networks with ties to Pakistan's intelligence agencies.



Additional Commissioner of Police, Special Cell, Pramod Kushwah said, "The first group was given the job of carrying out an attack using petrol bombs, with targets including important Government buildings or police stations in Delhi. Members of this group were reportedly working on logistics, scouting locations, and planning the timing of the attack. The second group focused on arms trafficking. This group received and distributed advanced firearms smuggled from Pakistan, mainly through drones along the Punjab border. Smuggling by drone has become a major challenge for border security, as it allows handlers to avoid checkpoints and deliver packages directly to designated locations before moving them to cities like Delhi".

Both groups were part of the larger Shahzad Bhatti network. Investigators describe Bhatti as a Pakistan-based operative accused of organising several terror and crime activities against India. The six people arrested are still in police custody, and more questioning is expected to reveal further details about the wider plot, Kushwah added.

Cases have been filed under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and other laws related to terrorism, arms smuggling, and conspiracy.

Senior police officers said this operation shows how tactics are changing, with direct attack planning now combined with crimes like arms and drug trafficking to support these networks. Using drones for smuggling is a new method meant to

avoid detection.

Security analysts called the operation a timely move that likely prevented potential loss of life and disruption in Delhi. The case underscores the need for ongoing interagency collaboration, enhanced surveillance, and robust border controls to combat these threats.

Delhi Police have asked the public to stay alert and report anything suspicious. The investigation is still underway, and more arrests may happen as it continues.

This development occurs as Indian security forces continue to dismantle several Pakistan-linked modules across various states. The Special Cell's success in this case reinforces its reputation for proactive, intelligence-driven operations against urban terror threats.

Child Protection Committees to be set up in all 5,633 schools by July-end

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Child Protection Committees will be constituted in all 5,633 schools across Delhi by the end of July, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta directed at a high-level review meeting at Raj Niwas on Monday.

In the meeting, they assessed the implementation of initiatives being carried out as part of the ongoing Child Protection Month and directed that measures adopted this month must become permanent features of all institutions rather than a one-time campaign.

The meeting was attended by the Chief Secretary, Commissioner of Police, Secretary of Education, Secretary of Women and Child Development, directors of both departments, the DCP SPUWAC, and senior officials across departments.

The context for Child Protection Month is a review meeting chaired by the LG on June 17, 2026, where it was decided to designate July as Child Protection Month. Since then, the Education Department, Delhi Police, and the Department of Women and Child Development have been running parallel initiatives across the city.

The Education Department informed the meeting that a comprehensive student safety checklist, in line with the guidelines of the National Commission



for Protection of Child Rights, the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights, and the POCSO Act, is being implemented across all 5,633 schools in Delhi.

These cover 1,077 Delhi Government schools, 198 Government-aided schools, 2,612 MCD, NDMC, and Delhi Cantonment Board schools, and 1,746 private schools. Teachers, school staff, and master trainers are being trained under POCSO Act provisions. Around 1,000 Educational and Vocational Guidance Counsellors are currently conducting awareness sessions for students on safe and unsafe touch, gender sensitisation, and personal boundaries. Self-defence training is also being provided. Special arrangements are being made for children with special needs.

Child Protection Committees have already been constituted in all Delhi Government schools. The direction issued on Monday extends this requirement to all 5,633 schools, including private, aided, and municipal schools, by the end of July.

Delhi Police told the meeting that special initiatives are underway for school children, missing children, children in parks and sports complexes, homeless children, children in JJ clusters, those at Bal Bhawan, and children living in orphanages and Child Care Institutions. An Additional DCP has been designated as the nodal officer for child safety in every district, reporting to the DCP SPUWAC. Schools are conducting awareness programmes covering the POCSO Act, school safety guidelines, cyber safety, bullying, and drug abuse.

The Department of Women and Child Development presented a large-scale POCSO awareness campaign plan covering Anganwadi-cum-PaIna Centres and all Child Care Institutions. Awareness will be targeted at children, their parents, and the wider community through videos, mobile awareness vans, and printed material.

The LG and CM directed that joint inspection teams comprising parent representatives, Education Department officials, Women and Child Development representatives, Delhi Police, and school heads be constituted to inspect all schools.

Delhi Police was directed to ensure prompt and coordinated action in every POCSO case registered. The meeting also directed that first-time juvenile offenders receive counselling and rehabilitation support for reintegration into society.

HC seeks Centre’s stand on plea of Gymkhana members against show-cause notice for eviction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

No effective hearing is likely to happen on Tuesday before the Centre's Estate Office dealing with the issue of eviction of Delhi Gymkhana Club from its premises on Safdarjung Road here, with the Delhi High Court deciding to hear the matter on July 28.

Justice Anvesh Jhingan on Monday sought the stand of the Centre on pleas by Delhi Gymkhana Club members and staff against the show-cause notice for eviction from the 27.3-acre facility and asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to ensure that the July 7 hearing before the Estate Officer is adjourned to a day after the next date of hearing.

Justice Jhingan issued notice to the central Government on applications seeking a stay on the operation of the show-cause notice, and granted it time to file its reply.

SG Mehta said the Centre would file its response to the applications. Noting that a hearing before the Estate Officer was scheduled for July 7, the senior law office added, "They can seek an adjournment there."

Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for the plaintiff, urged the court to give a short date in the matter. "Mr Mehta, we are keeping this for the date already fixed (in the main case). Just see it (Estate Officer's hearing) is adjourned beyond that date."



Justice Jhingan said.

The pleas by Vijay Khurana and Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd Staff Welfare Association form part of their pending lawsuit following the Land and Development Office's (L&DO) May 22 order terminating the perpetual lease deed and asking the colonial-era club to return its land by June 5 on grounds of "strengthening and securing defence infrastructure".

On June 29, the L&DO under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry issued the show-cause notice to the club, asking it to explain why an eviction order should not be passed against it under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971.

The notice, issued by Estate Officer Bipin Kumar Singh, directed the club and all persons concerned occupying the premises to submit their response by July 7 and appear for a personal hearing on the same day at 2.30 pm.

The move came more than a month after the Centre told the Delhi High Court on May 26 that it would not take forceful pos-

session of the 27.3-acre premises by June 5.

On May 26, the court observed that at that stage, there was nothing on record to suggest that authorities had initiated legal action for eviction and therefore no interim order was required on the lawsuits by the Gymkhana members and staff.

In his latest application, Khurana said the June 29 notice proceeds on "entirely erroneous and premature assumptions", which strike at the substratum of their pending lawsuit.

The application said the show-cause notice was "premature" as it wrongly presumed that the Gymkhana Club's perpetual lease was validly terminated.

It said the notice's continued operation would render the lawsuit infructuous, especially when the High Court had earlier observed that the question of valid termination would be determined at an appropriate stage. Besides a stay order, the application sought a direction for maintaining status quo on possession, occupation, user, and functioning of the club.

Govt to roll out 300 new electric buses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will roll out around 300 new electric buses on Tuesday, strengthening its bus fleet across the city.

According to officials, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will launch the buses in the RK Puram area of South Delhi, along with laying the foundation stone for a new bus depot.

Currently, Delhi has around 4,500 electric buses and a total of around 7,000 buses, making the national capital a city with one of the biggest EV bus fleets in the country.

The Rekha Gupta Government on June 30 notified the Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy 2026, which aims to accelerate EV adop-

tion, improve air quality and create a supportive ecosystem for electric mobility.

One aspect of the policy is that the Government will make efforts to induct only electric buses.

"All new intra-state buses to be inducted by the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and the Transport Department from the date of notification of this policy, shall be electric," the policy states.

In the past one year, the Delhi Transport Corporation has been increasing the numbers of its small 9-metre buses, which are expected to improve connectivity on certain routes.

The new steps to increase the number of buses are jointly funded under the PM E-Drive initiative of the Centre.



2 booked for running inter-State racket involving fake Government ID documents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An inter-state racket allegedly involved in preparing and selling forged Government identity documents through a website has been unearthed with the arrest of two persons. According to the Delhi Police's Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) unit, the accused have been identified as Bideshi Saw, a resident of Daman and Diu, and Santosh Kumar, a resident of Patna in Bihar.

"The duo operated the website bkprint.in, which enabled users to generate forged Aadhaar cards, voter identity cards, PAN-related documents, residence certificates, caste certificates, birth and death certificates and other Government document-like records after making online payments," Deputy Commissioner of Police (IFSO) Vinit Kumar said in a statement.

The forged documents closely resembled genuine Government-issued documents and were capable of being misused for

identity theft, impersonation, cheating, financial fraud and even for obtaining genuine Government documents on the basis of forged records.

"The case came to light during social media monitoring and cyber patrolling when information was received that forged Government documents were being prepared and supplied online through the website," the DCP said.

During verification, a team found that the portal was openly offering services for generating Aadhaar cards, voter identity cards, PAN-related documents, residence certificates, caste certificates, birth and death certificates and several other document-like records.

To verify the information, the IFSO team created a dummy user account using a mobile phone number. The website required users to recharge a digital wallet before availing its services. Accordingly, investigators transferred Rs 100 through the UPI ID displayed on the website.



After the wallet recharge was confirmed, police successfully generated forged Aadhaar and voter identity cards by entering fictitious personal details and uploading a photograph.

On examining the forged Aadhaar document, investigators found that the QR code merely stored the information manually entered by the user and

was not linked to the official Aadhaar database, conclusively establishing that the documents were fake.

The investigation further revealed that the mobile number and UPI account used for receiving payments on the website were linked to Saw.

A team was constituted. Following extensive technical

investigation, digital analysis and field verification, the team apprehended Saw from Daman and Diu.

During sustained interrogation, Saw disclosed that he was facilitating the preparation of forged documents through bkprint.in in exchange for online payments. He also revealed that the backend operations of the website were being managed by Kumar from Patna. Based on technical evidence and further investigation, police traced Kumar to Patna and apprehended him too.

A preliminary examination of the digital devices recovered from Kumar revealed website source code, hosting configurations, customer records, technical files, payment-related information and chats exchanged with Saw, establishing his active involvement in the development, maintenance and backend management of the websites used for preparing forged documents.

Police said the accused also managed another website, bkprint.xyz.

Police said the accused followed a simple but effective modus operandi. Customers were required to recharge a digital wallet before placing orders. After payment, users could enter arbitrary personal details and upload photographs to generate forged Aadhaar cards, voter identity cards and other Government document-like records.

"The accused allegedly generated QR codes that merely stored the information entered by customers, giving the forged documents an appearance similar to genuine Government-issued identity documents despite having no connection with official Government databases," the officer said.

According to police, such forged documents could be misused for identity theft, impersonation, cheating, financial fraud and obtaining genuine Government documents on the basis of forged records.

Police said Saw operated the website, received online pay-

ments through the linked UPI account, facilitated preparation and supply of forged Government documents and coordinated with Kumar for the backend operation of the portal.

Kumar designed, developed and maintained the backend infrastructure of bkprint.in and bkprint.xyz, managed website hosting, source code, customer database and technical operations, and enabled generation of forged documents.

Police recovered two mobile phones, a laptop and a QR code sound box from Saw. From Kumar, police recovered a laptop allegedly containing the website source code and technical records, a mobile phone containing chats with Saw, digital records relating to bkprint.in and bkprint.xyz, including source code, hosting details, customer database, technical files and payment-related information.

Police said further investigation is underway to identify other associates.

IN FOCUS



Vehicles are seen partially buried amid mud and boulders washed along the rain-triggered flash floods in Jammu and Kashmir, Monday

PTI

World’s largest botanical garden to come up in Chhattisgarh



PCCF Arun Kumar Pandey

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh Government is planning to develop a 350-acre botanical garden near the Jungle Safari in Naya Raipur under the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model with a minimum proposed investment of ₹550 crore.

The proposed project, located around 12 km from Swami Vivekananda Airport, aims to create a world-class botanical and eco-tourism destination while utilising land that has remained largely undeveloped. The State Forest and Climate Change Department has also proposed a 43-acre botanical garden at Nandanvan on Bhilai Road at an estimated cost of about ₹50 crore.

The final project cost would depend on the detailed project report and final design. As part of the investor outreach, representatives of several companies visited

the Jungle Safari, the proposed botanical garden site and Nandanvan on Monday before attending a meeting at Aranya Bhavan in Nava Raipur.

The meeting was chaired by Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (PCCF) Arun Kumar Pandey.

Among the firms that participated in the discussions were Noida-based Bhutani Group, Lucknow-based Shalimar Corp, Anopchand-Tilokchand Group, Avinash Group, Singhania Buildcon, Babylon Group, Myra Group, V-Net, Manoj Goyal and SDF Infra. The Forest Department has invited suggestions and proposals from prospective investors before finalising the projects. The proposed 350-acre botanical garden, if completed as planned, would be larger in area than the 326-acre Royal Botanic Gardens, Kew, in London and the 273-acre Acharya Jagadish Chandra Bose Indian Botanic Garden in Kolkata.

PM begins three-nation tour with Indonesia visit

The centuries-old temple, located approximately 17 kilometres northeast of Yogyakarta city, is considered Indonesia's largest Hindu temple.

Upon his arrival at the hotel, the Prime Minister witnessed cultural presentations, including the Ramayana and Bharatanatyam.

“Touched by the warm welcome from the Indian community in Jakarta. Their affection and deep commitment to India’s progress are truly inspiring. Our diaspora continues to strengthen India’s bonds with the world through its achievements across diverse fields,” Modi said.

Modi witnessed a captivating performance of Wayang Kulit, Indonesia’s treasured shadow puppetry tradition, bringing the timeless story of the Ramayana to life.

“It was a moving reminder of how our shared civilisational heritage has travelled across seas and generations, taking on beautiful local expressions while preserving its eternal values. My compliments to the team, which is known as Ganesh, for the performance,” he said.

Modi said he was delighted to witness a graceful Bharatanatyam performance by the Samanvaya Group. “It is gladdening to see these cherished traditions being preserved and presented with such dedication and excellence,” he added.

“The performance of ‘Homage to the Triple Gem’, by the artistes of the Vihara Dharma Ratna Group, was exceptional. It reflected the timeless teachings of Lord Buddha and the profound values embodied in the Triple Gem. It is heartening to see the rich Buddhist heritage being preserved and celebrated with such passion by the people of Indonesia,” he added.

Ahead of his departure from Delhi, Modi said his visit to Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand will further strengthen India’s Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR Vision as well as “our outlook towards a free and open Indo-Pacific.”

MAHASAGAR, or Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security Across the Regions, is India’s vision of security and growth for all

regions. Modi’s visit comes after President Prabowo’s state visit to India as the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations in January 2025.

“India and Indonesia share strong civilisational and people-to-people ties, and my visit will further deepen all aspects of our multifaceted partnership,” he said. From Indonesia, Modi will travel to Melbourne at the invitation of Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese. The final leg of the tour will take him to Auckland at the invitation of New Zealand Prime Minister Christopher Luxon.

ECI declares RS bypolls in West Bengal

The terms of Roy and Baraik were due to run till September 2029, while Dev’s tenure was to continue till April 2030. The TMC’s present strength in Rajya Sabha is nine.

The ECI announced the schedule for the bypolls, starting with the nominations from Tuesday till July 14, followed by scrutiny of nominations on July 15 and the last date of withdrawal of candidature on July 17. Polling would be held from 9am to 4pm in the West Bengal Assembly on July 24, after which counting of votes would start from 5pm that day.

With the BJP holding 208 seats in the 294-member Assembly, the numbers overwhelmingly favour the saffron camp. If it fields three candidates and its legislators vote along party lines, the party can comfortably secure around 70, 69 and 69 votes for its nominees respectively, making victory in all three contests a distinct possibility. The Mamata Banerjee camp sought to play down the significance of the possible Rajya Sabha setback, arguing that the vacancies were a consequence of “betrayal” by leaders who deserted the party during crisis.

“These seats belonged to the TMC and were won on the strength of the party in the last assembly election. A few individuals chose to desert the party after the results. The people of Bengal are watching who stood with them and who abandoned them at a difficult moment,” a senior leader aligned with the

Yogi dedicates Prerna Park to national icons

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj (UP)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Monday inaugurated Prerna Park here and unveiled statues of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Ashok Singhal, describing them as three great personalities whose lives were dedicated to nationalism, good governance and Sanatan values.

Addressing the gathering, Adityanath said India’s soul resides in Sanatan Dharma and Lord Ram represents the essence of the nation’s cultural unity.

“The soul of India resides in Sanatan Dharma, and Lord Ram is the primary source of India’s soul. Ram represents the nation and is the thread that binds India from north to south in unity,” he said after unveiling the statues. Paying tributes to Singhal, the chief minister said the late Vishwa Hindu Parishad leader devoted his entire life to Sanatan values and the nation.



UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath along with State Deputy Chief Minister Keshav Prasad Maurya and others during an event organised for the inauguration of Prerna Park in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh on Monday

PTI

“The grand Ram temple that we see today in Ayodhya and the transformed Ayodhya of today are founded on Ashok Singhal ji’s vision. The Ram Janmabhoomi movement was the biggest cultural movement after Independence, bringing saints from across the country onto one platform,” Adityanath said.

Recalling the Ram Janmabhoomi movement of

the 1980s and 1990s, he said slogans supporting the construction of the Ram temple resonated across the country, transcending barriers of caste, region and language under Singhal’s leadership.

The chief minister also said Singhal, an engineering graduate from Banaras Hindu University, chose to dedicate his life to the nation and Sanatan Dharma instead of pursuing a professional career.

Delhi MCD announces ward committee election schedule, polling on July 15

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Monday announced elections for six vacant seats in its Standing Committee and for chairpersons and deputy chairpersons of its 12 ward committees on July 15, more than a month after the polls were cancelled indefinitely.

The Municipal Secretary issued separate notices notifying the election schedule, stating that the last date to file nomination papers is

July 10. The elections were earlier scheduled for June 3 but were postponed “until further orders” on May 27. The MCD had not cited any reason for the decision. At the time, Leader of the Opposition Ankush Narang of AAP had alleged that the BJP had deferred the polls due to internal differences.

The Standing Committee currently has 12 members against its sanctioned strength of 18 after nine members retired on March 31 following the completion of the delayed draw of lots



process. Of the retired members, six belonged to the BJP and three to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP).

Subsequently, three vacancies were filled by the House on April 29, while six seats remained vacant. Jai Bhagwan

Landing, parking charges waiver for airlines unlikely to continue at major airports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Airports tariff regulator AERA is unlikely to extend the 25 per cent waiver in landing and parking charges for domestic flights across major airports, according to sources.

The Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA), on the civil aviation ministry’s directive on April 7, announced a three-month waiver for all domestic flights in the wake of the West Asia turmoil posing financial challenges for the airlines.

The sources on Monday



said that airport operators have not received any extension order regarding the reduced landing and parking charges, and, per se, the waiver has lapsed.

There was no immediate response from the civil aviation ministry on the issue. “Landing and parking

charges (part of aeronautical tariff) at all major airports shall be reduced by 25 per cent from the prevailing tariff. This reduction shall take effect immediately and will be applicable on all domestic flights for a period of three months,” AERA had said in its order dated April 7.

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Mamata Banerjee faction said. The rebel camp, however, maintained that the resignations reflected a broader crisis of confidence in the party’s leadership.

Delhi Police solves 29-year-old murder case

The deceased was later identified as 58-year-old Sharif Hasan Khan, a resident of present-day Ayodhya district in Uttar Pradesh, who worked at a clothing shop in Rajouri Garden.

The investigation at the time revealed that Fahim, who had come to Delhi in search of work, knew Khan. Police alleged that the two had an altercation on March 13, 1997, after Fahim stole money from the victim. During the dispute, he allegedly assaulted Khan with an iron rod, strangled him with a rope and concealed the body inside a wooden diwan storage box before fleeing.

Despite repeated efforts, the accused remained untraceable and was declared a proclaimed offender by a Delhi court in October 1997.

The investigation was recently handed over to the Central Range of the Crime Branch, which undertook a fresh review of the case. Special Commissioner of Police, Crime Division HGS Dhaliwal said, “Officers faced multiple hurdles, including the absence of recent photographs or reliable identification records and the fact that the investigation pre-dated modern digital policing tools.” Police said investigators relied extensively on field intelligence, developing local sources in the accused’s native village to establish that he was alive and occasionally visited the area. Surveillance and intelligence gathering eventually led the team to Lucknow’s Chowk Kotwali area, where his presence was confirmed, after which a raid was carried out in Thakurganj.

During interrogation, Fahim allegedly confessed to the murder, claiming it stemmed from a dispute over money. Police said he admitted to living under the alias ‘Ali Bhai’ after fleeing Delhi and spent the next 29 years moving between Nagpur, Mumbai and Lucknow while working as a Plaster of Paris artisan to avoid arrest.

Delhi Government likely to rename Mahila Samridhi Yojna to Delhi Laxmi Yojna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP-led Delhi Government is likely to rename its proposed ‘Mahila Samridhi Yojna’ — monthly assistance of ₹2,500 for eligible women — as ‘Delhi Laxmi Yojna’ before rolling it out, a source said.

The Government has also prepared a registration portal for the scheme and is planning to launch a mobile application aimed at enhancing women’s safety, the source said.

The scheme, one of the BJP’s key promises made during the 2025 Delhi Assembly polls, is expected to benefit around 17 lakh women from economically weaker sections in the national Capital.

The Women and Child Development Department, headed by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will implement the scheme.

The scheme was earlier expected to be announced on June 1. However, its launch was deferred as the government decided to rename it, the source told PTI.



The source further said that the registration portal has been readied and is likely to become operational soon after the scheme is formally launched.

In the 2026-27 Budget presented in March, Gupta allocated ₹5,100 crore for the scheme. A similar allocation had also been made in the previous fiscal, but the rollout was delayed due to the lack of authenticated data for verifying eligible beneficiaries.

The Chief Minister has repeatedly said the scheme would be

launched only after putting in place a foolproof mechanism to ensure that the benefits reach genuine beneficiaries.

A committee headed by Gupta was constituted in March last year to oversee the implementation of the scheme. It includes several Cabinet ministers.

The source said the eligibility criteria have also been finalised. Women possessing a Delhi Aadhaar number and belonging to the below poverty line category will be eligible to apply for the monthly financial assistance.

Gurugram launches inspection drive for school buses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Gurugram

Following the Haryana Human Rights Commission’s directives, the Gurugram administration began a special joint inspection drive for school buses to ensure safe school commutes for students, an official said on Monday.

On the first day of the drive, 105 buses operated by various schools underwent thorough inspections regarding all safety standards prescribed under the Safe School Vehicle Policy and Motor Vehicle Rules, the official said.

“On the first day of inspection, irregularities were found in only a few buses and notices will be issued to concerned school operators. If deficiencies are not rectified within a week, action will be taken accord-



ing to the rule,” said Harendra Veer, ADTO and Assistant Secretary (RTA), Gurugram.

The special campaign will continue for 15 consecutive days, during which approximately 4,500 school buses operating in the district will be inspected, he said.

people amid heavy rains. They said the downpour over the past few days exposed “crumbling infrastructure” across Mumbai and other parts of the state.

NIA charges Hafiz Saeed for Pahalgam terror...

The chargesheet also listed several individuals, including commander of LeT and TRF such as Habibullah Malik, also known as Sajid Jatt, Saifullah, or Sajid Saifullah Jatt, as a key handler and mastermind. The document described a conspiracy planned in Pakistan, supported by digital records, forensic analysis, human intelligence, and the recovery of weapons and communication devices linked to Pakistan. It further describes the use of safe houses in Pakistan and local support networks in Jammu and Kashmir. The latest supplementary chargesheet names Hafiz Saeed and provides more details about Pakistan’s involvement and his role in planning and directing the attack from across the border. The NIA says the attack was carried out by terrorists sponsored by Pakistan and linked to LeT and TRF. On April 22, 2025, three armed men attacked tourists at Baisaran meadows near Pahalgam in Anantnag district, Jammu and Kashmir. The attackers, who carried M4 carbines and AK-47 rifles, targeted male tourists after asking about their religion and forcing some to recite Islamic verses. A local Muslim pony operator was also killed.

During the investigation, the NIA questioned more than 2,800 people, detained several suspects, and found incriminating evidence. Three attackers were later killed in encounters. The agency also requested legal help from China to trace the supply chain of electronic devices, including a phone connected to the attack.

The case is still under investigation, and the NIA says it is reviewing more evidence. This filing comes nearly 14 months after the attack, which led to strong diplomatic and security actions from India, including cross-border strikes on terror sites in Pakistan.



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

“आप, इस बार सब को साथ जोड़ कर- स्वच्छता और वृक्षारोपण के लिए कुछ प्रयास जरूर करें। आप, खुद भी पेड़ लगाइये और दूसरों को भी प्रेरित करिए।”
नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री



मिशन 70 लाख पौधा रोपण अभियान का शुभारंभ

एवं

300 इलेक्ट्रिक बसों सहित विभिन्न परियोजनाओं का लोकार्पण

मुख्य अतिथि

श्री अमित शाह

माननीय केंद्रीय गृह एवं सहकारिता मंत्री, भारत सरकार

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री भूपेंद्र यादव

माननीय केंद्रीय पर्यावरण, वन एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन मंत्री,
भारत सरकार

सरदार तरनजीत सिंह संधू

माननीय उपराज्यपाल, दिल्ली

श्रीमती रेखा गुप्ता

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

श्री हर्ष मल्होत्रा

माननीय केंद्रीय राज्य मंत्री
(सड़क, परिवहन और राजमार्ग तथा कॉरपोरेट कार्य)

श्री आशीष सूद

माननीय गृह मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार

सरदार मनजिंदर सिंह सिरसा

माननीय पर्यावरण, वन एवं वन्यजीव मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार

डॉ. पंकज कुमार सिंह

माननीय परिवहन मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार

सुश्री बांसुरी स्वराज

माननीय सांसद, नई दिल्ली

श्री प्रवेश वाही

माननीय महापौर,
दिल्ली नगर निगम

श्री अनिल कुमार शर्मा

विधायक, आर के पुरम



सुबह 10:30 बजे | 7 जुलाई 2026 | मंगलवार



स्थान- सेंट्रल पार्क, सेक्टर-12, आर के पुरम, नई दिल्ली-110022



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States Focus



PERMISSION MANDATORY FOR RSS MARCH: PRIYANK KHARGE

Karnataka Home Minister Priyank Kharge on Monday said prior permission is mandatory for the RSS to hold its route march in the state, as long as he remains a minister. He asked, if permission is required even for a small Ganesh pandal to be erected during the Ganesh Chaturthi festival, shouldn't an organisation, which is called "world's biggest NGO" and receives donations from foreign countries, seek permission when hosting mega events? "It (permission) is required because, as we (the Government) submitted to the High Court following the stampede incident (outside Chinnaswamy Stadium during RCB IPL victory celebration in 2025) the criterion for seeking permission for mega events applies. Accordingly, let them seek permission; whether to grant it or not is left to us," he said.



MANJHI ROOTS FOR SEPARATE ELECTORATES FOR SCs, STs

Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi on Monday lamented the condition of Scheduled Castes in the country, and called for separate electorates for SCs and STs where only people belonging to these communities would vote. Addressing party workers during the State council meeting of Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular), the party chief said, "Had Dr BR Ambedkar's views prevailed in the 1932 Poona Pact, leading to separate electorates for SCs and STs where only voters belonging to these communities would vote, the outcome would have been entirely different." He claimed that since universal voting is allowed in seats reserved for SCs and STs, voters belonging to "dominant" castes exert influence over elected candidates. "In reserved constituencies, our people do vote, but when it comes to earning a livelihood, they are the ones who are left to till the land and earn wages. It is the influential people who take it all," the former CM said. He alleged that Mahatma Gandhi's fast-unto-death before the Poona Pact had forced Ambedkar to concede his demand. The ideological tussle between Gandhi and Ambedkar on separate electorates for SCs and STs had culminated in the Poona Pact wherein the latter consented to allowing separate electorates where all voters.

Bharat Taxi to expand to 500 cities in 2 years: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Amit Shah on Monday announced a cooperative life insurance company and said 'Bharat Taxi' services will expand to 500 cities within two years. Speaking at the 5th Foundation Day of the Ministry of Cooperation in New Delhi, Shah said the ministry has revitalised the cooperative movement, which he described as neglected under previous Governments.

He also stressed the need to eliminate corruption in professional appointments to strengthen credibility in the cooperative sector.

India has around 8.5 lakh cooperatives with more than 30 crore members. Shah said the ministry has introduced several policy measures to modernise the cooperative system, making it more transparent, technology-driven, and competitive. He noted that 'Bharat Taxi', a ride-hailing platform under a cooperative model, will expand to 500 cities over the next two years.

Shah added that the cooperative sector will establish a life insurance company to support growth in the insurance industry. He noted that IFFCO-TOKIO, a joint venture involv-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressing the 5th Foundation Day ceremony of the Ministry of Cooperation at the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi on Monday

ing fertiliser cooperative IFFCO, is already active in this sector.

In India, there are 26 life insurance companies.

Bharat Taxi, operated by Sahakar Taxi Cooperative Ltd, is a driver-focused mobility platform under the cooperative model. It has 6.37 lakh registered drivers and 35.77 lakh registered customers.

Bharat Taxi operates under Sahakar Taxi Cooperative Ltd in Delhi-NCR, Gujarat, Lucknow, Chandigarh, Mumbai, Jaipur, and Kanpur. It is scheduled to launch in Ranchi, Patna, Guwahati, Bhopal, Kolkata, Indore, and Nagpur in the coming months.

Shah noted that cooperatives have expanded into sectors beyond

Amarnath cave's ice stalagmite shrinking rapidly

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

The naturally formed ice stalagmite in the Amarnath cave shrine is melting fast, raising concerns among devotees and shrine board authorities.

Since the beginning of the pilgrimage on July 3, more than 65,000 pilgrims have already performed *darshan* inside the holy cave till late Monday evening. Each day, a large number of pilgrims reach Pahalgam and Baltal base camps to undertake the pilgrimage.

According to ground reports, it is the second consecutive year that a naturally formed ice stalagmite has begun melting in such a short period. The pilgrimage is scheduled to culminate on August 28, coinciding with Shravan Purnima and Raksha Bandhan.

A devotee from Jammu who performed *darshan*



inside the cave shrine on July 4 told *The Pioneer* that the ice stalagmite was fast shrinking due to the heavy influx of pilgrims in the cave area.

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, who is also the Chairman of the Shri Amarnathji Shrine Board, said an overwhelming number of devotees are arriving for the Amarnath pilgrimage, including many without prior regis-



tration. He urged unregistered pilgrims to wait for their turn, noting that the number of pilgrims allowed on both routes is capped in accordance with Supreme Court guidelines and cannot be increased. The LG said the administration is making every effort to ensure a safe and smooth pilgrimage and appealed to devotees to cooperate with authorities and follow prescribed directions.

In Jammu, Inspector General of Police (IGP) BS Tuti appealed to the pilgrims not to travel to Kashmir without valid registration. The Divisional Commissioner, Jammu, Ramesh Kumar, said only registered pilgrims are allowed to proceed and appealed to devotees to follow all security and traffic advisories to ensure a smooth pilgrimage.

Haryana: Surjewala alleges irregularities in HTET exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Congress MP Randeep Singh Surjewala on Monday alleged large-scale irregularities in the Haryana Teacher Eligibility Test (HTET) for TGT and PRT levels, claiming that the examination process had been marred by broken seals on question paper packets, printing errors, and incomplete questions.

Surjewala sought a judicial inquiry by a sitting judge of the high court into the entire HTET examination process. In a statement, the Congress leader alleged that after irregularities reported in the HTET PGT (Level 3) examination held on July 4, more serious lapses surfaced during the TGT (Level 2) or Trained Graduate Level and PRT (Level 1) or Primary Teacher examinations conducted on July 5. He claimed that seals of



question paper packets were found broken at several examination centres in various districts, including Rewari, Jhajjar, Rohtak, Faridabad and Ambala, raising concerns over the confidentiality of the examination.

The Congress leader further alleged that the TGT and PRT papers contained numerous errors, including missing underlined words, incomplete questions, incorrect translations, meaningless words, duplicate answer options and discrepancies between the Hindi and English versions of several questions.

INS Mahendragiri to Join Navy on July 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indigenous stealth frigate 'Mahendragiri', endowed with state-of-the-art weapons, including surface-to-surface and surface-to-air missile systems, and a cutting-edge sensor suite, is set to be commissioned into the Indian Navy on July 11, officials said on Monday.

Designed by the Navy's Warship Design Bureau (WDB) and built by MDL Mumbai, 'Mahendragiri' is the sixth ship of the Nilgiri-class (Project 17A). It is capable of undertaking anti-air, anti-surface and anti-submarine operations, and is equally suited for maritime security, power projection, humanitarian assistance and



disaster relief (HADR), search and rescue, and sustained presence missions, a Navy spokesperson said.

"The frigate is equipped with an advanced suite of indigenous and state-of-the-art weapons and sensors, including surface-to-surface and surface-to-air missile systems, sophisticated elec-

tronic warfare capabilities, comprehensive anti-submarine warfare systems and an integrated combat management system," the official said.

Incorporating advanced stealth features, enhanced survivability, reduced radar signature and a high degree of automation, the frigate is

powered by a modern Combined Diesel or Gas (CODOG) propulsion system, enabling high-speed operations with "exceptional endurance across the full spectrum of maritime missions".

"With over 75 per cent indigenous content, 'Mahendragiri' exemplifies the Government of India's Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative," the Navy said.

Named after the Mahendragiri mountain range in the Eastern Ghats, the frigate embodies resilience, strength and unwavering resolve, the Indian Navy said.

It will serve as a "formidable force multiplier, safeguarding nation's maritime interests and contributing to a

secure, stable and prosperous Indo-Pacific," the Navy said.

The frigate was delivered on April 30 at Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDSL), Mumbai. Its construction has brought together a vast network of Indian industries, including numerous Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), generating employment while strengthening the nation's defence industrial base, it said.

The commissioning of this frigate marks another significant milestone in the successful execution of the Project 17A programme. The ships under this programme are fitted with an advanced weapon and sensor suite as compared to the P17 (Shivalik-class).

Adani Group to build ₹2,500-crore defence manufacturing hub in MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

In a major boost to India's defence manufacturing ambitions, the foundation stone for Adani Group's proposed ₹2,500-crore defence manufacturing facility was laid in Shivpuri, Madhya Pradesh, on Friday. The project is expected to emerge as South Asia's largest private missile ecosystem and strengthen the country's indigenous defence production capabilities.

The ceremony was attended by Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, along with senior officials from the Adani Group, including Jeet Adani and Karan Adani.



According to the company, the integrated facility will support the entire missile manufacturing value chain—from sourcing raw materials to producing mission-ready systems at a single location. The plant is also expected to manufacture a range of modern defence equipment, including assault rifles,

pistols, sub-machine guns and other military hardware for the armed forces.

The investment is projected to generate over 2,000 direct and around 10,000 indirect employment opportunities, while contributing to infrastructure and industrial development in the Shivpuri region.

Punjab Police Counter-Intelligence wing busts 8 terror modules in 2026, arrests 117

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

In the first five and a half months of 2026, the Punjab Police's Counter-Intelligence (CI) Wing acted against several terrorist groups in the State. Official data shows that between 1 January and 19 June 2026, the Wing dismantled eight terrorist modules, arrested 117 suspects, and solved nine terror-related cases. These results show the Wing is becoming more effective, with faster responses and important recoveries of weapons, explosives, and drugs.

Punjab is still a main target for Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) and Khalistani extremist groups such as Babbar Khalsa International (BKI). Handlers based in Pakistan, Europe, or the Gulf continue to send weapons and explosives and spread radical ideas. By working with State Special Operations Cells (SSOCs), district police, central agencies, and other states, the CI Wing has stopped several plots before they could become major attacks.

Several major operations in early 2026 highlight this trend. In

April, the CI Wing and Gujarat's Anti-Terrorism Squad broke up a terror group backed by the ISI. They arrested three people from Amritsar and Tarn Taran and seized hand grenades and a modern pistol. The group was connected to handlers in Pakistan and planned to disrupt peace in Punjab.

Shortly after, SSOC Amritsar, SSOC Mohali, and the CI Wing worked together to break up another ISI-backed group. They arrested one person who had four hand grenades and two foreign pistols. Early investigations connected this person to a recent grenade attack in Chandigarh. Director General of Police Gaurav Yadav said the accused was acting on orders from foreign handlers.

Quickly solving attacks has been another important achievement. In early June, Gurdaspur Police and the CI Wing solved a grenade attack in Kalanaur in only six hours. They arrested the main suspect using both technical tools and information from people. The investigation pointed to a handler based abroad. In another case in May, three suspects were arrested in a different



Punjab DGP Gaurav Yadav

Gurdaspur grenade case, and another grenade was found at a suspect's home. Both cases involved UAPA and Explosive Substances Act charges and were linked to foreign handlers. has also handled overlapping threats.

In May, CI Amritsar broke up a group linked to BKI, arrested two associates of foreign handlers, and seized two hand grenades intended for attacks on Government offices. Other operations led to the recovery of five Glock pistols in Ferozepur, several pistols and

heroin in Amritsar and Tarn Taran, and weapons connected to terror-gangster networks with handlers in Germany and Dubai.

The CI Wing responded quickly to a new ISI tactic involving SIM-enabled, solar-powered spy cameras placed near sensitive military and police locations to monitor movements and send footage. The Wing noticed early signs of this threat in late March and early April 2026, before similar detections were made elsewhere.

The Punjab Police stopped



recruits before they could use the cameras. State-wide checks and warnings to other agencies prevented several attempts. This proactive approach also helped wider efforts, as information from Punjab led to the identification and arrest of Pakistan-linked suspects in 17 states and union territories since mid-2025.

Drug and arms smuggling groups, often linked to terror funding, have also faced major crackdowns. CI units in Amritsar, Ferozepur, and other areas seized

large amounts of heroin, foreign pistols, and cash, all connected to handlers across the border. In total, eight modules were busted, 117 people were arrested, and nine incidents were solved, resulting in improved security. Several planned grenade attacks on police and infrastructure were stopped. Investigations have often traced these networks to foreign handlers and built connections to support more arrests.

The CI Wing's work shows strong teamwork with other

agencies and effective use of technology, including CCTV, call records, digital evidence, and human sources in border areas. DGP, Punjab Police, Gaurav Yadav, has often emphasised "a zero-tolerance approach to terror, organised crime, and narco-terror links". "Operations usually result in quick FIRs at SSOC police stations and thorough investigations. Because of this, the CI Wing has been able to resolve cases in hours or days rather than weeks, which has increased deterrence and public trust", the DGP told *The Pioneer*.

ISI still targets radicalised youth and diaspora groups and uses hawala channels. Foreign handlers keep changing tactics, moving from direct attacks to hybrid threats like spying, fake currency, and using gangsters. Even so, Punjab Police's CI Wing has shown it can keep up with these changes through speed, accuracy, and determination. In a border state with a complex history, these results in just five and a half months are impressive. They show that proactive intelligence, strong action, and teamwork are the most effective ways to fight terrorism.

BJP slams Congress for opposing bill to oust jailed ministers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday alleged that Congress' resistance to a bill, which allows the removal of prime minister, chief ministers and ministers if they are in judicial custody for 30 consecutive days in cases of serious criminal offences, came from a "sense of entitlement" that it should not be stopped from indulging in corruption.

The ruling party's remarks came a day after Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said the party will strongly oppose the proposed Constitution amendment, claiming it is aimed at the "political harassment" of adversaries. BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the proposed legislation seeks to bring uniform standards of accountability for those holding executive offices.

"There are some people who have a huge sense of entitlement. They feel that corruption is their right. They will indulge in corruption, and if anyone catches them, they will cry persecution.



BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

"This kind of sense of entitlement towards corruption and crimes is being struck down," he said in a video statement. Referring to former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, he questioned whether an elected executive can continue to govern from prison. "We have seen that even the Constitution's founding fathers had not imagined that if a chief minister or somebody (in Government) went to jail, they would not resign. We saw this in the case of Arvind Kejriwal, who continued to run the Government from jail. Can that be possible administratively? It is also a question of integrity," he said. Poonawalla also accused

Opposition parties of adopting double standards on the issue of resignation from public office. "They used to call for the resignation of people at the hint of an allegation. Now, when they are sent to jail by courts in case after case, they are not resigning," he alleged.

The BJP spokesperson questioned why elected representatives should be treated differently, making a case for a common standard for public office holders and ordinary citizens.

"If a common man goes to jail, will he be allowed to continue in his job even for one day? He will be immediately suspended. Then why should there be a separate legal

standard for those holding elected and executive posts?" he asked.

He said the bill has already been referred to the Joint Committee of Parliament and asked opposition parties to wait for its recommendations instead of opposing it outright. "Let the committee come out with its report. Why are people opposing it? Do they not want integrity and propriety in public life? Do they have a sense of entitlement that they are allowed to indulge in crime and corruption?" Poonawalla asked.

Alleging that the Congress is shielding those accused of corruption, he claimed Prime Minister Narendra Modi is working to change that political culture. "It seems that, for them, it is not a Government of the people, by the people and for the people. It is a Government of criminals, by criminals and for criminals. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is fighting this mindset," Poonawalla alleged.

According to sources, the parliamentary panel examining the related bills is likely to adopt its report on July 17 and submit it in the Lok Sabha.

Assam Cabinet clears 7 bills to boost business, MSMEs

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Assam Cabinet has approved seven bills, including those dealing with ease of doing business and facilitation for setting up MSME units, to be introduced during the upcoming Budget session of the Assembly, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has said. It also approved on Sunday an integrated emergency response system to be operated by the police and a new dairy infrastructure by AMUL, he said.

The Budget session of the State Assembly will commence on Monday. Sarma, addressing a press conference after chairing the Cabinet meeting, said among the seven bills approved is the Assam Land and Revenue Regulation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which allows the sale of land in the vicinity of religious places, iconic structures, etc., only to those who have been living in these areas for the last three generations in Barpeta, Batadrava and Majuli.

"This Bill was approved by the Assembly earlier, but when it was sent for Presidential assent, the Centre made a few suggestions to make it stronger. These have been added, and the new amendment Bill will be brought," he said. The Assam Ease of Doing Business (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which will facilitate single-window clearance for establishing various ventures, was also okayed by the Cabinet.

The Assam Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (Facilitation of Establishment and Operation) Bill, 2026, was also green-lighted by the council of ministers. It will enable the setting up of MSME units in the non-polluting sectors without prior



Government approval for the first three years, he said. The Cabinet gave its nod to the Assam Tourism (Development and Registration) (Amendment) Bill, 2026, dealing with registration of homestays, hotels, etc.

The colonial-era Sarais Act will be repealed as its provisions have been incorporated in the new bill, Sarma said. During the meeting, the Assam Jan Vishwas Bill, 2026, was also approved, which relaxes some provisions of town and country planning rules and land reclassification rules, among others.

The Cabinet also okayed the Guwahati Satellite City Development Authority Bill, 2026, Sarma said, adding that it will put to rest speculations that private investors were being handed over the project.

"Many people were saying that we were planning to give land to Adani and Ambani in the name of developing the satellite city. Now, everyone will under-

stand that it is the Government that will develop it," he said.

The chief minister maintained that if corporate groups like Adani and Ambani made major investments in the state, it would lead to an economic boom.

The council of ministers also cleared a proposal for an emergency response system, to be available on dialling 112, integrating police, fire, health and disaster response services into a unified, 24x7, technology-driven platform, Sarma said.

For this purpose, a new emergency response centre will be established at the Lachit Barphukan Police Academy in Dergaon, and the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing will be onboarded to implement the Assam Police Emergency Management System Project (Dial 112), he added.

"States like Uttar Pradesh and Telangana have been implementing such an integrated helpline service, and we will follow suit now," Sarma said.

Austerity measures announced earlier were relaxed partially by withdrawing the restriction imposed on foreign visits by ministers and Government employees.

"With prior permission from the Government, employees can undertake foreign travel for personal reasons. Also, official visits for training and other purposes will be allowed," Sarma said.

The Cabinet also approved amendments to the Assam Minor Mineral Concession Rules, 2013, to address operational gaps, seasonal supply disruptions and inadequate enforcement mechanisms.

SIR: NDA leaders allege mass irregularities in Karnataka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

A delegation of NDA leaders on Monday submitted a formal complaint to Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar, alleging "massive irregularities" in the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls in the state and demanded an immediate inquiry and door-to-door re-verification of all enumeration forms.

They also sought strict legal action against all officials and political functionaries found responsible for these "irregularities".

The delegation comprising Union Minister and JD(S) leader HD Kumaraswamy, Union Ministers from BJP Pralhad Joshi and Shobha Karandlaje, Leaders of Opposition in Karnataka Assembly and Council R Ashoka and Chalavadi Narayanaswamy, and senior leaders from both parties, met CEO Anbukumar and submitted the complaint.

"We write to express serious concern over the massive irregularities in the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls in Karnataka. The officials who are supposed to conduct the SIR are showing zero regard for the approved process, thereby undermining the very spirit of democ-



Union Ministers HD Kumaraswamy, Pralhad Joshi, Karnataka Assembly LoP R Ashoka and others at the State election office in Bengaluru

racy," the leaders said in the letter. Noting that Booth Level Officers (BLOs), under the direction of the District Election Officer (DEO/DC), are required to conduct mandatory door-to-door verification and personally verify the identity of members of each household as per SIR guidelines, they claimed this was not being followed on the ground; evidence has been shared on social media, and mainstream media have also carried it.

Multiple complaints are being received from several other parts of the state, they added.

Alleging that enumeration forms are being filled out while sitting at community halls, mosques, and the residences of BLOs, the NDA leaders said WhatsApp

groups have also been created for the purpose, and people are being encouraged to visit these community halls and mosques for the SIR process.

"Such a practice is a breach of the established SIR guidelines and raises serious concerns regarding the neutrality and secular character of the electoral process. The SIR is conducted to strengthen the integrity of the electoral rolls, but the manner in which BLOs are conducting the exercise defeats the very purpose of the revision," they said.

According to the delegation, this will create an "unsustainable and unreliable" electoral roll. "No deviation is allowed from the procedures prescribed by the Election Commission of India".

Two held for chawl collapse that killed 6 in Mumbai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Two persons were arrested on Monday in connection with the chawl collapse in the Mankhurd area a day earlier, which killed six, a police official said. The three-storey chawl (row tenement) collapsed on Sunday night in Janta Nagar in Mandala locality in the eastern part of the metropolis following heavy rains.

An FIR was registered under sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for culpable homicide not amounting to murder as well as other offences on the complaint of one Mohammad Mukhtar Abdul Ali Shaikh (53), and two persons have been arrested,



the Mankhurd police station official said.

The case has been regis-

tered against the building owner, the contractor involved in the construc-

tion, the hutment owner, and other private individuals and Government officials

Final electoral rolls will be error-free: Manipur CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Monday exuded confidence that the final voter list following the Special Intensive Revision would be inclusive and error-free, a day after the poll panel published the draft rolls leaving out 1,58,677 names.

The draft rolls were published on Sunday, following the completion of the enu-



Y Khemchand Singh

meration phase of the exercise, with 19.34 lakh voters retained. Those who were not included in the draft

rolls can file claims and objections from July 5 to August 4. The final electoral roll will be published on September 6.

After attending a workshop on Special Intensive Review (SIR) Phase II at the BJP State office, the chief minister said he was confident that the exercise would be inclusive and the final voter list would be error-free.

State BJP president and Rajya Sabha MP A Sharda

Devi, Home Minister K Govindas Singh, former MP Vinod Sonkar, MLAs, and senior BJP leaders also attended the workshop.

In a social media post, Singh said, "The workshop focused on the draft electoral roll published by the Election Commission of India following the successful completion of the enumeration phase of the SIR, during which over 19.34 lakh enumeration forms were collected."

BRICS anti-drug agencies meet in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

A two-day meeting of the heads of anti-drug agencies from BRICS member countries is set to begin here on Monday, with the discussion expected to focus on enhancing intelligence sharing and cooperation to combat narcotics trafficking, officials said.

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the deliberations, being hosted by the Narcotics Control Bureau, will help the BRICS nations tackle drug abuse more effectively. In a post on X on Sunday, he said, "Assam looks forward to



hosting this important meeting and welcomes all participating delegates." "India is making excellent progress towards a drug-free society, and tomorrow's deliberations will help to deepen coordination amongst BRICS members in tackling this menace," Sarma added.

Officials said the global drug trafficking landscape

has seen a profound change, with the proliferation of synthetic drugs, new psychoactive substances, darknet-enabled trafficking and cryptocurrency-based financial flows posing complex transnational challenges. The two-day meeting will focus on three priority areas — combating synthetic drugs and precursor diversion,

strengthening intelligence sharing and operational coordination, and capacity building and institutional cooperation.

The BRICS, initially comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa, expanded in 2024 to include Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the UAE, with Indonesia joining in 2025. It has emerged as an influential grouping as it brings together 11 major emerging economies of the world, representing around 49.5 per cent of the global population, around 40 per cent of the global GDP and around 26 per cent of the global trade.

4 killed, 5 injured as truck collides with SUV in Madhya Pradesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sehore

Four persons were killed and five others sustained injuries after a truck collided with an SUV in Madhya Pradesh's Sehore district on Monday, police said.

The collision occurred near Godi Jod on the Ashta-Shujalpur Road around 2.30 pm, an official said.

Four people travelling in the SUV were killed on the spot, while five others sustained injuries and were admitted to a hospital, he said. Police and ambulances arrived at the scene and extricated the victims from the SUV, which was completely mangled due to the impact of the crash, Parvati Police Station in-charge Harisingh



Parmar said. Two of the deceased were identified as Inder Singh and Rajaram, residents of Bhiyapura in Rajgarh district, while police were in the process of ascertaining the identity of the others. As per preliminary investigations, nine people were travelling in the SUV, transporting a mentally ill person for treatment.

Two-day BRICS Women's Working Group meet begins in Kochi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Monday began the two-day BRICS Women's Working Group Meeting in Kochi, with senior officials from BRICS member countries discussing women's empowerment and women-led development under its BRICS Chairship 2026.

"India commenced the BRICS Women's Working Group (WWG) Meeting in Kochi, Kerala, under its BRICS Chairship 2026. Senior Government officials from the BRICS Member Countries are participating in the two-day meeting



Representatives of the BRICS member countries posing for a group photograph during the BRICS Women Working Group (WWG) Meeting in Kochi, Kerala

to deliberate on key issues relating to women's empowerment and women-led development while strengthening cooperation across areas of shared interest," the Ministry of Women and Child Development said in a statement.

Welcoming the delegates, Secretary in the Ministry of Women and Child Development Anil Malik said that while geography kept the countries physically apart, their shared commitment to advancing women's empowerment had kept them closely connected. "While geography kept us physically apart, our shared commitment to advancing women's empower-

ment has kept us closely connected," Malik said. He expressed confidence that the meeting would facilitate meaningful discussions, mutual learning and constructive collaboration, further strengthening the collective commitment of BRICS countries towards the empowerment of women.

Referring to India's BRICS Chairship, Malik said the Women's Track had been guided by four priority areas reflecting the shared aspirations of BRICS nations and contemporary global challenges.

These include building a more resilient BRICS through women's governance and leadership; advanc-

ing financial and digital inclusion as catalysts for change; promoting women's entrepreneurship and skill development; and strengthening women's role in climate action, food security and nutrition, he said.

He noted that these priorities have provided a strong framework for engagement over the past several months and will continue to guide the deliberations during the Kochi meeting. Malik also expressed confidence that the constructive spirit demonstrated by member countries during the preparatory consultations would continue to shape the discussions over the next two days.

AIAWU slams Union Govt over proposed ration quota cut



AIAWU President A Vijayaraghavan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Agricultural Workers' Union (AIAWU) on Monday strongly condemned the Department of Food and Public Distribution's proposed amendment to the National Food Security Act (NFSA), 2013, labelling the move to alter ration quotas as "apathy towards the working class."

The farm labourers' body took sharp objection to the proposed bill, which seeks to replace the existing fixed foodgrain entitlement of 35 kg per household per month with a 7 kg per person monthly allocation, while retaining an overall household cap of 35 kg.

In a joint statement, AIAWU President A Vijayaraghavan and General Secretary B Venkat argued that the restructuring would severely hit large, impoverished families. "The Government claims this will fix inequitable distribution between small and large families. However, by capping the total monthly ration at 35 kg per household, families with more than five members will automatically receive less than the promised 7 kg per capita," the leaders stated.

Citing recommendations from the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), which suggests at least 14 kg of foodgrains per person for healthy development, the union noted that medical experts and nutritionists have consistently demanded an increase, rather than a reduction, in existing quotas.



Editor's
TAKE

A flood of neglect, not just rain

Every year the rains return and Mumbai drowns. This year's erratic monsoon should force some overdue questions about who is accountable.

Mumbai is underwater again, and the experience suggests it always will be, year after year. This week's red alert brought shuttered schools, a landslide on the Mumbai-Pune highway, suspended flights, and a collapsed chawl in Mankhurd that killed six people. The Andheri subway went under, as it does every year. Low-lying junctions across the suburbs turned into small lakes, as they do every year.

None of this is a surprise. It is a script the city re-enacts each monsoon, and the real tragedy is not the rain – it is our refusal to prepare for it. Ask who is responsible, and the honest answer is: everyone, which is another way of saying no one. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, among the richest civic bodies in the country, still treats desilting as a pre-monsoon ritual rather than a year-round discipline. This year's Mithi river desilting contract was cleared only in April, and was still short of the halfway mark with barely two weeks left before the BMC's own deadline.

The state government has a long history of eyeing wetlands and salt-pan land for real estate instead of guarding them as flood buffers. Builders have spent three decades concretising floodplains and mangroves that once absorbed this very water – the Bandra-Kurla Complex itself rose on reclaimed Mithi wetlands, shrinking the river to half its original width. Add unregulated construction and dumping along the banks, and a river built to carry the suburbs' stormwater now struggles to carry itself.

None of this is new information. The Supreme Court rapped civic authorities for neglecting the Mithi as far back as 2017. Auditors have already flagged crores spent on the river's clean-up between 2013 and 2016 that were never properly accounted for. Every year the contracts are signed late, the monsoon arrives on time, and residents pay the difference in flooded homes and lost workdays. This year carries an added complication: erratic monsoon rains. The India Meteorological Department went into the season expecting just 90 per cent of the long-period average rainfall, with an El Nino pattern likely to suppress rain across most of the country. Yet Mumbai and the Konkan coast have been battered by intense, concentrated bursts – some parts of the city logging close to 600mm of rain in just four days – after a noticeably drier June. That is the real climate story: not simply more or less rain, but rain arriving in fewer, fiercer spells that would strain even a well-maintained drainage system, and Mumbai's is far from that. Cities can no longer plan around an "average" monsoon when the average itself is breaking down. None of this is unfixable. It requires desilting audited by independent engineers, not self-certified by the same contractors year after year; encroachments removed regardless of whose signature approved them; and mangroves and wetlands treated as flood infrastructure rather than land banked for the next tower. Mumbai does not lack money, expertise, or warning. It lacks the will to treat this as a crisis for twelve months of the year, instead of remembering it only in July.

The enduring legacy of Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee

Beyond his political life, he was a visionary institution builder who believed that universities, scientific establishments, industries, cultural organisations and constitutional bodies were the true foundations of a strong and self-reliant India. His enduring contribution offers valuable lessons for a nation striving to become a developed nation while retaining its heritage



GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT

History often remembers great leaders through the political battles they fought. Yet the most enduring contribution of statesmen is rarely confined to politics alone. Their real legacy lies in the institutions they create, the ideas they nurture and the values they leave behind for future generations. As the nation commemorates the 125th birth anniversary of Bharat Kesari Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee, it is worth revisiting an aspect of his public life that deserves far wider attention: his lifelong commitment to institution building as the foundation of nation building.

Independent India did not emerge merely from a political struggle. It had to build universities capable of educating its citizens, research institutions that could advance scientific knowledge, industries that could generate economic self-reliance, cultural organisations that would preserve civilisational heritage, and public institutions that could uphold democratic values. Dr. Mookerjee understood early that a nation's future depends not only on visionary leadership but also on strong institutions that outlast individual leaders and governments.

His remarkable academic career reflected this conviction. Appointed the youngest Vice-Chancellor of the University of Calcutta, he assumed office at a time when higher education was becoming central to India's intellectual awakening. For him, universities were not merely places that produced graduates; they were institutions that shaped informed citizens capable of contributing responsibly to public life. Education, in his view, was inseparable from the larger task of nation building.

His commitment to scientific and technological advancement extended well beyond the university campus. As a member of the Court and Council of the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru, he contributed to strengthening one of India's premier centres of scientific research. In 1947, he laid the foundation stone of the Department of Power Engineering, recognising that engineering education and technological capability would become indispensable to an independent India's economic progress. Long before innovation became a central policy objective, he had recognised that scientific excellence and industrial development would determine the country's long-term strength.

This vision found practical expression after Independence when Dr. Mookerjee became India's first Minister for Industry and Supply.



DR. MOOKERJEE'S VISION OFFERS AN IMPORTANT REMINDER. ECONOMIC GROWTH ALONE CANNOT DEFINE NATIONAL PROGRESS. LASTING DEVELOPMENT REQUIRES SUSTAINED INVESTMENT IN EDUCATION, SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH, TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION, CULTURAL PRESERVATION AND INSTITUTIONS THAT INSPIRE PUBLIC CONFIDENCE

The writer is Union Minister for Culture & Tourism, Government of India

ature and scholarship. His correspondence shows the assistance he extended to the eminent poet Kazi Nazrul Islam during a period of personal difficulty. Such episodes remind us that public leadership is often measured not only by major policy decisions but also by quiet acts of generosity that seldom attract public attention.

Dr. Mookerjee carried the same institutional outlook into the Constituent Assembly. Describing the framing of the Constitution as "a great responsibility" and "a solemn and sacred trust", he underlined the moral obligations that accompany constitutional governance. Those words remain strikingly relevant today. The strength of the Constitution ultimately depends not only on its written provisions but also on the integrity of Parliament, the independence of public institutions, the rule of law and the civic responsibility of citizens. Constitutional democracy flourishes only when institutions command public trust and operate with integrity.

As India advances towards the goal of becoming a developed nation, Dr. Mookerjee's vision offers an important reminder. Economic growth alone cannot define national progress. Lasting development requires sustained investment in education, scientific research, technological innovation, cultural preservation and institutions that inspire public confidence.

Roads, airports and factories are indispensable, but so are universities that encourage inquiry, laboratories that expand knowledge, museums that preserve heritage and public institutions that safeguard constitutional values. Institutions possess a remarkable quality: they outlive governments, political movements and even generations. They preserve accumulated knowledge, provide continuity amid change and enable societies to pursue long-term national goals. Leaders may shape history, but institutions sustain civilisation.

That perhaps is the most enduring lesson of Dr. Syama Prasad Mookerjee's public life. His legacy rests not merely in the offices he held or the debates in which he participated, but in his unwavering belief that strong institutions are the true custodians of a nation's aspirations. As India continues its journey of development, strengthening those institutions that promote knowledge, scientific temper, cultural confidence and constitutional values would be the most meaningful tribute to his memory.

PIC TALK



Ahead of World Chocolate Day, Chefs of IIHM Institute of Patisserie and Culinary (IIPC) display various varieties of chocolates, in Bengaluru

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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Why quiet contributors deserve more than applause



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

In contemporary organisations, the ability to draw attention is increasingly being misunderstood for the ability to generate effect. Visibility often wins faster attention than consistency and noise is frequently valued over content. As these organisations become more driven by optics and perception, a key question emerges: are we actually acknowledging contribution or just applauding performance that is easier to notice? Well, a simple metaphor describes this: the difference between a fish employee and a chicken employee. A fish moves quietly, adapts to changing conditions and keeps progressing steadily without seeking attention. On the other hand, a chicken is loud and highly visible, creating constant activity around itself. While both may contribute, visibility and noise should not be mistaken for meaningful or consistent performance. This seemingly

humorous metaphor illustrates a larger workplace issue: organisations typically reward people who are most visible rather than those who regularly generate outcomes. Across industries, praise typically goes to individuals who demonstrate their activities successfully, while silent participants undertaking unseen yet vital roles remain neglected. The tragedy is not merely that loud contributors are rewarded. The real loss is that silent contributors slowly stop giving their best.

Institutions are often held together by those who work beyond the spotlight, sustaining stability despite uncertainty. Ironically, their reliability often works against them; quiet proficiency is rewarded with greater responsibility but rarely with attention, until dedication gradually transforms into exploitation. This phenomenon is noticeable primarily at educational institutions, where visible achievements such as board results, public events, competition victories and social media milestones are extensively celebrated. Yet behind every success lies the invisible labour of teachers and staff providing emotional support, resolving conflicts, offering remedial guidance, managing administrative demands, communicating with parents and handling crises. Much of this vital labour remains unnoticed simply because it does not produce immediate visibility or public applause. The silent instructor who regularly alters learning results may receive less appreciation than someone who just shows enthusiasm in public spaces.

In the process, leadership judgment often becomes distorted, with visibility mistaken for ownership, constant

updates for productivity and relentless activity for dedication. More often than not, the calmest individual in the room may be carrying the heaviest responsibility. The deeper concern lies in what modern workplaces have started rewarding. In an age shaped by constant broadcasting, being seen is increasingly valued as much as actual work. This performative mindset has quietly entered professional spaces, where productivity is often judged less by outcomes and more by visible busyness. Emails become signals, meetings become stages and activity begins to overshadow impact. The consequences are profound. Quiet high performers burn out; mediocrity learns the art of self-promotion and organisations gradually become ecosystems where optics overshadow substance. Trust erodes, collaboration weakens and thoughtful contributors withdraw from environments that reward volume over value. This raises an uncomfortable but necessary question: Are we rewarding genuine contribution or merely performance theatre? The answer often defines institutional health. Strong leadership lies in seeing beyond noise. Recognising those who bring stability in crises, deliver consistently and strengthen systems without seeking applause. What truly matters is who keeps the organisation moving forward when conditions become difficult. Wise institutions understand this. They do not measure worth by spectacle alone but by sustained impact.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

TEEJAN BAI KEPT THE MAHABHARATA ALIVE FOR THE WORLD

If one voice could bring the Mahabharata alive for millions, it was undoubtedly that of Teejan Bai of Chhattisgarh. Generations have been captivated by her extraordinary Pandavani performances, where the epic was not merely narrated but dramatically experienced.

Through her commanding voice and remarkable storytelling, the courage of Bhima, the anguish of Draupadi, the dilemmas of Arjuna and the wisdom of Krishna unfolded before audiences with rare emotional intensity. Teejan Bai also challenged deep-rooted social conventions.

At a time when folk performance was largely dominated by men, she fearlessly carved her own place and transformed the Kapalik

style of Pandavani into a powerful theatrical tradition. Armed with only a tambura, she effortlessly turned it into Bhima's mace, Arjuna's bow or Krishna's chariot, transporting audiences into the heart of the Mahabharata. India's civilisational heritage has survived not only through written scriptures but also through gifted storytellers who kept its traditions alive.

Teejan Bai belonged to that timeless lineage. Honoured with the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award, the Padma Shri and the Padma Vibhushan, she elevated a regional folk art to global acclaim, ensuring that India's greatest epic continues to inspire generations. She may not be with us but her voice will always be with us!

VIJAY SINGH ADHIKARI | NAINITAL

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Loneliness is a silent public health emergency

Loneliness has quietly emerged as one of the most serious public health challenges of our time, affecting millions across the world. According to Age UK, more than a million elderly people in Britain go for a month or longer without speaking to a friend or family member. Such prolonged social isolation is far more than an emotional burden; it has profound physical and psychological consequences. Research has shown that chronic loneliness elevates stress hormones, weakens immunity and increases the risk of heart disease, depression, dementia and premature death. Older adults are particularly vulnerable.

The loss of a spouse, close friends or family members, declining health and reduced mobility often leave them isolated. Even those who once enjoyed active social lives may find it difficult or embarrassing to admit they feel lonely. As a result, many suffer in silence. Combating loneliness does not always require grand interventions. A simple phone call, a visit, a patient conversation or a reassuring presence can make an enormous difference. Families, communities and governments must work together to ensure that our senior citizens feel valued, connected and supported. No one should have to spend the final years of life feeling forgotten or alone.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Defective medicines demand zero tolerance

The tragic deaths of five expectant mothers in a Rajasthan hospital, reportedly linked to defective oxytocin injections manufactured by a laboratory in Amritsar, represent far more than an industrial lapse. They constitute a grave breach of public trust. Every medicine is expected to save lives, not end them. This disturbing incident exposes serious shortcomings in pharmaceutical manufacturing, regulatory oversight, quality assurance and post-market surveillance. Such failures cannot be dismissed as isolated accidents. They highlight the urgent need for stricter inspections, rigorous testing and greater accountability throughout the drug supply chain. Those found responsible must be given exemplary punishment.

Merely suspending or cancelling a manufacturing licence is insufficient when negligence results in irreversible human loss. Regulatory authorities must also review existing safety protocols to prevent similar tragedies in the future. The bereaved families deserve substantial compensation, although no amount of financial assistance can replace the lives lost or erase the trauma they now endure. Every patient has the right to safe and effective medicines, and protecting that right must remain the foremost responsibility of both manufacturers and regulators.

BRIJ B. GOYAL | LUDHIANA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Make temple donations transparent

With reference to the report, "Ram Temple Trust to meet amid donation row" (July 5), the controversy highlights the urgent need for stronger systems to safeguard public donations. The Sri Ram Temple Trust should establish a comprehensive standard operating procedure that minimises cash and jewellery contributions by promoting secure digital and banking channels. The Special Investigation Team must be allowed to conduct a thorough and impartial inquiry. Its mandate should include forensic examination of electronic devices belonging to all individuals under suspicion so that every person involved is identified. Investigations of this nature require patience and should not be rushed merely to satisfy public sentiment, as incomplete inquiries often weaken prosecutions.

The Trust should also ensure that donations are invested promptly through regulated banking instruments and other secure financial avenues to minimise the risk of misuse. Since these offerings are made by devotees for a noble cause, the Trust should honour Lord Ram's ideals by supporting education and healthcare, particularly in underserved areas. Tax laws should encourage such public welfare initiatives by extending suitable exemptions to charitable spending on these essential sectors.

VINOD JOHRI | DELHI



‘Confidence comes from action, not slogans’



Good governance today is impossible without technology. For too long, citizens have associated government schemes with paperwork, delays and repeated visits to different offices. We are changing that mindset. The EV Policy adopts a digital-first approach. Incentives will be processed through transparent online platforms using Direct Benefit Transfer, ensuring benefits reach eligible citizens directly without unnecessary intermediaries. The Single Window Clearance system will simplify approvals for charging operators, reducing delays and improving accountability, says Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, treading on the Viksit Bharat path laid by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. She talks further on governance of NCT Delhi in an interview to Executive Editor Deepak Kumar Jha and Associate Editor Rajesh Kumar of *The Pioneer*.

Your government has been in office for over a year. How do you rate your performance?

Rekha Gupta : The final report card of any government is written by the people, not by the government itself. Having said that, I can say with satisfaction that in our first year we have focused on changing the culture of governance in Delhi. For too long, governance became synonymous with announcements. Our effort has been to restore the culture of implementation. Every department has been given measurable targets, timelines and accountability. We review progress regularly because public trust is built through delivery, not declarations. Whether it is cleaning the Yamuna, strengthening flood preparedness, improving public infrastructure, expanding welfare delivery, introducing the new EV Policy, accelerating regularisation of colonies or improving coordination among departments, our approach has been consistent - identify the problem, fix responsibility and monitor execution. Of course, one year is only the beginning. Delhi has accumulated challenges over many years, and no responsible government should claim that every problem has already been solved. But I believe people can clearly see the difference in intent, work culture and administrative seriousness. We did not come to occupy the office. We came to change outcomes. Our benchmark is not yesterday's politics. Our benchmark is tomorrow's Delhi.

What gives you the confidence that Delhi can emerge as India's EV capital?

Confidence comes from preparation, not slogans. Delhi already has one of the largest EV markets in the country. Our citizens adopt new technology quickly when they see value and convenience. We also have an extensive public transport network, a strong power distribution system and an entrepreneurial ecosystem that is ready to embrace innovation.

But our confidence is based on something even stronger. This policy does not focus on only one aspect of EV adoption. It builds the complete ecosystem.

We are targeting nearly 32,000 public charging points, backed by an investment of ₹1,000 crore for charging infrastructure. Delhi Transco Limited has been made the nodal agency to ensure planning, deployment and maintenance. A High-Powered Committee chaired by the Chief Secretary will continuously monitor implementation. New public infrastructure will be EV-ready from the design stage itself.

At the same time, we are supporting consumers through purchase incentives, scrapping incentives, road tax and registration fee exemptions. Commercial drivers, delivery fleets, manufacturers, mechanics and charging operators have all been included in the policy. Cities become leaders when policy, infrastructure and public participation move together. Delhi has all three. I do not doubt that just as Delhi once became the country's leader in Metro connectivity and CNG-based public transport, it can now become India's Electric Vehicle Capital.

What is your vision behind the Electric Vehicle Policy, and how do you see it transforming Delhi over the next five years?

This policy is much bigger than electric vehicles. It is about the kind of Delhi we want to build for the next generation. For too long, development and environment were presented as competing priorities. We reject that thinking. I believe that a modern city must also be a healthy city. Economic growth and clean air must move together. Delhi has always led India - whether in education, entrepreneurship, technology or public transport. Now it is time for Delhi to lead India's green mobility revolution. Our EV Policy is therefore not merely a transport policy; it is an economic policy, an environmental policy and a public health policy rolled into one.

Over the next five years, Delhi will witness a complete transformation in the way people move. Charging infrastructure will expand rapidly, public transport will become cleaner, commercial mobility will increasingly shift to electric vehicles, and thousands of green jobs will be created for our youth. Every charging station that comes up, every electric auto that replaces a polluting vehicle and every family that

chooses an EV will contribute to a cleaner Delhi.

Most importantly, this policy has been designed around the common citizen. It reduces the cost of ownership, creates reliable charging infrastructure, supports businesses and strengthens implementation. We are not asking citizens to adjust to the policy; we are designing the policy around the lives of citizens. Governments should not merely respond to the future; they should prepare the future. This policy is our preparation for the Delhi of 2030 and beyond.

How will this policy help improve Delhi's air quality and contribute to a healthier environment for residents?

The biggest beneficiary of this policy is not the automobile industry. It is the health of Delhi's people.

According to the Commission for Air Quality Management, vehicular emissions contribute around 23% of Delhi's winter air pollution. Three-wheelers alone account for nearly 19% of vehicular pollution, while two-wheelers constitute almost 67% of Delhi's vehicle population. That is why our policy prioritises exactly these high-impact categories first.

Beginning in January 2027, new registrations of eligible three-wheelers and light commercial goods vehicles will progressively move towards electric mobility. From April 2028, new registrations of two-wheelers will also transition in phases. These are the vehicle segments that travel the longest distances every day and therefore contribute significantly to emissions.

The impact goes beyond pollution figures. Cleaner air means fewer respiratory illnesses, healthier children, lower healthcare costs and a better quality of life for every family. This is perhaps one of the biggest investments we can make in preventive healthcare.

Every electric vehicle replacing a polluting vehicle is not merely a transport decision; it is a public health intervention. Our objective is not only to improve Delhi's Air Quality Index. Our objective is to improve the quality of life of every Delhiite. Because clean air is not a privilege. It is every citizen's right.

What are your plans to ensure charging stations are easily accessible to every Delhiite?

No EV policy can succeed unless people are confident that charging is available wherever they go. That is why, for us, charging infrastructure is not an afterthought, it is the foundation of this policy.

Today, Delhi has around 9,000 public charging points. Our target is to take this number to nearly 32,000 during the policy period. That means adding roughly 23,000 new charging points across residential colonies, markets, office complexes, Metro stations, parking facilities, highways and public spaces.

But we have learnt an important lesson from the past. Success is not measured by how many charging stations are inaugurated; it is measured by how many are actually working. Therefore, Delhi Transco Limited has been made the nodal agency not only for deployment but also for ensuring uptime, maintenance and service quality. A High-Powered Committee headed by the Chief Secretary will continuously monitor implementation. A Single Window Clearance mechanism will remove unnecessary approvals so infrastructure comes up faster.

For citizens living in apartments and group housing societies, DISCOMs have been directed to facilitate separate EV charging meters, while RWAs are being encouraged to develop common charging facilities.

Our vision is that no Delhiite should have to plan their journey around a charging station. Charging stations should become as common and dependable as petrol pumps are today. That is how confidence is built.

How will the incentives under the new EV Policy make electric vehicles more affordable for middle-class families and first-time buyers?

Every middle-class family calculates every major purchase carefully. Buying a vehicle is not just an emotional decision; it is a financial decision.

Our responsibility as a government is to ensure that choosing a cleaner vehicle does not become an expensive choice. That is precise-

ly why this policy combines purchase incentives, scrapping incentives, complete exemption from road tax and registration fees, and direct benefit transfers.

For two-wheelers, which are the preferred mode of transport for lakhs of Delhi families, purchase incentives have been designed to bridge the price gap between petrol vehicles and EVs. For four-wheelers, owners scrapping older BS-IV and earlier vehicles can receive a ₹1 lakh scrapping incentive, in addition to the existing tax benefits.



Commercial vehicles also receive substantial financial support because they operate every single day and generate higher savings over time. But affordability is not only about the purchase price. An electric vehicle costs significantly less to run and maintain than a conventional vehicle. Lower fuel costs, fewer moving parts and reduced maintenance expenses translate into long-term savings for families. The best subsidy is the one that reduces a family's monthly expenses for years, not just on the day of purchase.

Our objective is to make electric mobility the sensible financial choice for the middle class, not merely an environmentally conscious one.

How do you expect it to benefit auto-rickshaw drivers, delivery partners, taxi operators, and small businesses?

Whenever we design a policy, we ask ourselves one question: How will this improve the life of someone who earns every day to support their family? For an auto-rickshaw driver, a delivery partner or a taxi operator, a vehicle is not just transport; it is the family's primary source of income. Every rupee saved on fuel directly increases household income. That is why commercial mobility is one of the biggest focus areas of this policy.

Eligible e-autos will receive purchase incentives of ₹50,000, along with scrapping incentives for replacing older vehicles. Commercial goods vehicles receive incentives of up to ₹1 lakh, besides support available under the Government of India's PM E-DRIVE programme. Battery swapping and charging infrastructure will also expand rapidly, reducing downtime and increasing productivity.

This transition will also benefit thousands of neighbourhood businesses, from charging station operators and battery service providers to local workshops, fleet managers and technology companies.

A good policy should improve both the environment and the economy. This policy does both. Cleaner vehicles, lower operating costs and higher income, which is a win for drivers, businesses and Delhi.

Technology is a key component of the new policy. How will digital platforms and smart monitoring improve transparency and the overall user experience?

Good governance today is impossible without technology. For too long, citizens have associated government schemes with paperwork, delays and repeated visits to different offices.

We are changing that mindset.

The EV Policy adopts a digital-first approach. Incentives will be processed through transparent online platforms using Direct Benefit Transfer, ensuring benefits reach eligible citizens directly without unnecessary intermediaries. The Single Window Clearance system will simplify approvals for charging operators, reducing delays and improving accountability.

Technology will also help monitor charging infrastructure, service quality and system performance in real time. Instead of reacting after complaints are received, we want government agencies to identify problems early and resolve them quickly.

For citizens, this means a smoother experience, from applying for incentives to locate charging stations to accessing government services. Technology should not make government bigger; it should make government simpler. That is our approach to governance: not more files, but faster decisions; not more procedures, but better services.

Some experts say EVs are not safe. What is your take or experience?

Every new technology faces questions in its early years. That is true for electric vehicles as well. But we must separate isolated incidents from scientific evidence.

Today, EV technology has evolved significantly. Battery chemistry, thermal management systems and manufacturing standards have improved tremendously over the last few years. Across the world, millions of electric vehicles operate safely every day. Our government's responsibility is not to dismiss concerns but to address them through strong standards and proper regulation.

That is why our policy gives importance to certified charging infrastructure, authorised battery management, scientific recycling and strict compliance with safety norms. Delhi Pollution Control Committee will issue detailed guidelines for battery management, while manufacturers will continue to remain responsible for battery quality and safe end-of-life disposal.

I would also encourage citizens to buy vehicles only from authorised manufacturers and avoid unsafe modifications or uncertified charging equipment. Technology itself is neither safe nor unsafe. Safety comes from standards, regulations, and responsible use. My own experience has been that once people understand the technology and begin using EVs, hesitation gradually gives way to confidence. That is exactly how every major technological transition has happened in history.

What is your plan to reduce traffic jams across the city?

Traffic congestion affects productivity, public health, business activity and the quality of life of every Delhiite. Every minute lost in traffic is time taken away from families, work and economic growth. There is no single solution to congestion. It requires better planning, smarter technology and stronger coordination among agencies. Our government is working on multiple fronts simultaneously. We are expanding electric public transport, encouraging greater use of shared mobility, improving last-mile connectivity, strengthening traffic management systems and accelerating infrastructure projects that remove major bottlenecks. We are also working closely with Delhi Traffic Police and other agencies to use technology for better traffic regulation and real-time monitoring.

The EV Policy itself contributes to this effort. Cleaner public transport, electric buses, electric autos and organised charging infrastructure will make public mobility more efficient and encourage people to gradually shift away from excessive dependence on private vehicles. Encroachment removal is another important priority because roads are meant for movement, not obstruction.

We have already initiated sustained drives to reclaim footpaths and public spaces, and this effort will continue with strict monitoring. A world-class capital cannot spend its future waiting at traffic signals. Our objective is to build a Delhi where mobility is faster, safer, cleaner and more predictable. Ultimately, good governance is measured not by how many roads are built, but by how smoothly people can travel on them.

Parking is another issue here. Is the government planning to bring any parking policy?

Yes. Parking is one of the biggest urban governance challenges that Delhi face today. For many years, parking was treated as an afterthought. As vehicle ownership increased, our cities did not expand at the same pace. The result is visible on almost every road today.

Our approach is that parking has to become scientific, technology-driven and well-regulated. We are working towards better utilisation of existing parking spaces, improved digital management, stronger enforcement against illegal parking and greater integration between parking facilities and public transport. Future planning must also anticipate future mobility. That is why our EV Policy requires new public infrastructure to be EV-charging-ready from the design stage itself.

Similarly, future parking infrastructure must also be planned with electric mobility in mind. At the same time, we cannot allow public roads to become permanent parking lots. Roads are public assets and must primarily serve mobility. Every square metre of public space in Delhi is valuable. It should be managed, not misused. Our objective is to create a parking ecosystem that is transparent, technology-enabled and convenient for citizens while ensuring smoother traffic movement across the city.

Monsoon has arrived in Delhi. Every year, we see roads getting flooded and severe waterlogging. What preparations has your government made this time?

Delhi has suffered for years because preparations often began after the rains had already arrived. We decided to reverse that approach. This year, planning started well before the monsoon season. A comprehensive Flood Control Order 2026 has been issued after a detailed review at the highest level.

Every identified waterlogging point in Delhi has been assigned a dedicated nodal officer, with clear accountability. If waterlogging occurs, responsibility is fixed, not diffused. A 24x7 Central Flood Control Room has been operational since 15 June, using digital monitoring of rainfall and water levels.

Major and minor drains have undergone time-bound desilting, mobile pumping units have been deployed for emergency response, and sector-level coordination committees are functioning across departments. We have also identified vulnerable low-lying areas based on the lessons of the 2023 floods, with evacuation plans and emergency response systems already in place. Can any government promise that there will never be heavy rainfall? No. But what a government can promise is preparedness instead of panic, coordination instead of confusion and accountability instead of excuses. That is exactly what we have tried to institutionalise this year.

Cleaning of Yamuna is still an issue?

The Yamuna is not merely a river. It is Delhi's identity, our civilisational heritage and a lifeline for millions of people. For decades, governments spoke about cleaning the Yamuna. Unfortunately, the gap between announcements and outcomes kept widening. We have adopted a different approach. Instead of treating Yamuna cleaning as a symbolic exercise, we are treating it as a mission with continuous monitoring.

Work is progressing simultaneously on desilting, drain management, sewage treatment, interception of untreated wastewater and inter-agency coordination. This is a challenge that has accumulated over several decades. It cannot disappear in a few months. Anyone making such a promise would not be speaking honestly. However, citizens have every right to expect visible progress, and that is exactly what we intend to deliver.

Every drain that is intercepted, every sewage treatment plant that becomes functional and every stretch of the river that is restored brings us one step closer to that goal. The Yamuna does not need another slogan. It needs sustained work, scientific planning and political commitment. I assure the people of Delhi that our commitment is absolute because the future of Delhi and the future of the Yamuna are inseparable.

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Order Order

Allahabad HC declines to hear PIL in Ram temple donation row



The Allahabad High Court on Monday declined to entertain a PIL seeking an independent probe into the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, observing that a petition on the same issue is already pending before the Supreme Court.

A Lucknow bench of the court comprising Justices Rajan Roy and Manjive Shukla disposed of the PIL filed by Mohit Ashok.

The petitioner had sought an independent investigation into the alleged embezzlement of donations and offerings made by devotees at the Ram temple.

The plea also sought directions for an audit of the temple's finances by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG).

Observing that the matter is already under consideration before the Supreme Court, the high court declined to examine the merits of the petition and disposed of the case.

(PTI)

Karur stampede: SC to hear DMK plea on July 7

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to list on July 7 a plea filed by the DMK alleging that ministers in the Tamil Nadu Government were "actively influencing" witnesses in the CBI probe into last year's Karur stampede case.

A partial working day bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and Sheel Nagu agreed to list the matter on Tuesday after senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi, appearing for DMK Secretary RS Bharati, sought an urgent hearing.

The plea also seeks to restrain Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, state minister Aadhav Arjuna and other accused people from making public statements on the case and to regulate their interaction with victims' families during the pendency of the CBI probe.

Ahmadi told the court that witnesses were being "actively influenced" by ministers in the state Government and expressed apprehension that Vijay's proposed visit to Karur on July 10 to meet victims' families could affect the investigation.

Ahmadi submitted, "This court directed a CBI probe. Now, some accused who are now ministers in the present regime are attempting to actively influence the witnesses. We have filed an application".

He said the petitioner can demonstrate from the record that witnesses were being influenced.

The bench then said, "We will have it tomorrow".

The plea referred to reports that the chief minister is scheduled to visit Karur to distribute Government orders, compassionate appointments and other benefits to the families of the deceased and injured victims.

Bharathi, who has sought impleadment in a pending case, submitted that several people initially chargesheeted in the case were now ministers in the Tamil Nadu Cabinet following the 2026 assembly elections.

(PTI)

HC quashes man's job offer over his social media posts

A person has the right to profess his religion, but that cannot be construed as permission to hurt others' faith, the Calcutta High Court has observed while setting aside a man's appointment as an assistant professor at a college here over his social media posts.

This came on the plea of the Ramkrishna Mission College in West Bengal's Narendrapur against a single bench's September 4, 2025, order, directing the institute to appoint Tamal Dasgupta as an assistant professor of English.

A division bench led by Justice Debansu Basak and also comprising Justice Md. Shabbir Rashidi held the candidate's social media posts had the potential of hurting the sentiments of the followers of other religions.

Noting that Dasgupta expressed strong views about religions other than that of his own, it held the candidate's contention that his fundamental right of freedom of speech and to practice religion were affected by the college's decision to refuse him appointment cannot be accepted.

The court also noted that Dasgupta had made social media posts prior to the West Bengal College Service Commission's recommendation for his recruitment to the position, expressing strong views on religions, the conduct of the Ramkrishna Mission of which the college is a part, and the monks of the order. Passing the judgment last week, the division bench said, "Every person has the fundamental right to profess his or her religion."

(PTI)



Supreme Court uses pedestrian safety to signal a new era of civic accountability



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The Supreme Court on June 19, 2026, delivered a judgment declaring the "Right to Walk Safely on Demarcated Footpaths" as a Fundamental Right under the Constitution.

The 13-page verdict starts on a very emotive tone: "Like any young father, the appellant lovingly readied his five-year-old son and left home at 9 am to drop him at the neighbourhood school. Who could have ever imagined that it would be the last walk with his son? As the father and son were walking towards the school, a tanker came from behind and struck the boy, crushing his waist and lower body. He succumbed to the injuries."

The judgment continued: "Take it for granted, there was neither a footpath nor a pedestrian crossing." "Accidents like this continue to occur; perhaps they are inevitable till we restructure our rights regime as regards access to roads and recognise their correlative duties. Till then, we will continue to cope with these tragedies by routinely transforming them into FIRs and Motor Accident Claims. We are not referring to road safety, for this Court is deeply concerned about it and is, in fact, monitoring the implementation of safety guidelines. "The issue is something more fundamental, and it is in recognition of the simplest of the simple human activity- 'Walking'. While the right to walk is inextricably connected to life, our

Constitution recognises and guarantees it as a fundamental right - "All citizens shall have the right to move freely throughout the territory of India," the judges wrote.

The Supreme Court used this heartbreaking story to expose a massive flaw in how our cities are built. For decades, urban planning has prioritised cars and bikes while completely ignoring the people who walk. The judges pointed out that society has become numb to these tragedies.

Instead of fixing the dangerous roads, we simply turn a person's death into police paperwork and insurance claims. The Apex Court refused to let this continue, stating that safe walking is a basic human necessity that cannot be treated as an afterthought. Moved by this tragic loss of life, the Top Court delivered a historic and landmark judgment. It officially declared that the "Right to Walk Safely on Footpaths" is a Fundamental Right under the Constitution. The judges ruled that the freedom to move freely across the country is completely meaningless if a child cannot even walk to school safely.

By anchoring this right under Article 19 and Article 21, the Supreme Court made it a mandatory duty for local Governments to build and protect safe walkways for every citizen. To make this right a reality, the Supreme Court strongly attacked the "elitism of wheels." The judges criticised urban planning for always prioritising cars and bikes over people who walk.

The Supreme Court declared that a pedestrian's right is primary and must come before motorised vehicles. It shifted the focus from merely managing traffic to protecting human dignity, demanding



that walkers be treated as equal citizens rather than obstacles on the road.

The Apex Court did not just give a lecture; it issued strict orders to back it up. It directed the Union Ministries to create a brand-new legal framework to protect pedestrians. It also ordered the creation of a specialised regulatory body to design and enforce safe walking spaces. Most importantly, the judges ruled that citizens can now take local municipal bodies to court if their neighbourhood footpaths are missing, broken, or blocked. This historic judgment does not just stop at road safety. It serves as a sharp reminder to Government authorities about several other basic rights that have been ignored for decades.

By focusing on the "simplest of simple human activities," the Supreme Court has opened the door for citizens to demand accountability in all areas of daily life. Just like safe walking, access to clean drinking water, breathable air, and unpolluted surroundings are vital parts of the Right to Life under Article 21.

Yet, millions of citizens still face

toxic air quality, open sewage, and broken civic infrastructure every single day. Government agencies often treat these basic survival needs as secondary issues rather than constitutional guarantees.

By holding local municipalities directly accountable for missing footpaths, the Supreme Court has set a powerful precedent. It sends a clear message to the state: public infrastructure is a fundamental right, not a charitable favour.

This ruling reminds authorities that they cannot continue to escape their duties by hiding behind a lack of funds or bureaucratic delays when the lives of citizens are at stake.

To guarantee these basic rights for every citizen, the media and the judiciary must work together as powerful watchdogs. The media has a crucial role to play in keeping these issues alive. Instead of moving on after a tragedy, journalists must consistently expose broken infrastructure, question local leaders, and give a voice to affected citizens. By keeping the spotlight on Government failures, the media can create public pressure that forces authorities to act.

Allahabad High Court asks Centre, ASI to file counter-affidavit in Tejo Mahalaya dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court on Monday asked the Centre and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to file a counter-affidavit on a writ petition seeking a declaration that the Agreshwar Mahadev Nagnatheswar Virajman Tejo Mahalaya temple is present inside the Taj Mahal premises.

The petition was filed on July 3 by the Agreshwar Mahadev Nagnatheswar Virajman Tejo Mahalaya temple, Hari Shankar Jain and four others.

Hari Shanker Jain submitted before the court that his application for appointing an advocate commissioner as well as for photography of premises in dispute was



wrongly rejected by the trial court, and thereafter, the revision was dismissed as not maintainable. Though the same is necessary for the adjudication of a dispute.

After hearing Jain, Justice Rohit Ranjan Agarwal asked the Central Government as well as ASI to file a counter-

affidavit in the matter and also issued notice to Pankaj Kumar Verma, who is the respondent No 4 in the writ petition.

The petition was filed against the orders of the district court at Agra by which the Civil Judge (Senior Division), as well as the Additional District Judge,

had declined to issue an order appointing an Advocate Commission to survey the disputed premises. A declaratory suit was filed in 2015 and is pending in the court of the Civil Judge (Senior Division) at Agra, seeking a declaration that the Agreshwar Mahadev Nagnatheswar Virajman Tejo Mahalaya temple is present in the Taj Mahal premises.

Pending suit, an application to appoint an advocate commissioner was moved, but both the district courts had declined to pass an order in the matter, which has been challenged in the present petition.

The Union of India, the Archaeological Survey of India and Pankaj Kumar Verma have been made parties-in-response.

Thane court acquits man accused of stabbing nephew

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A court in Maharashtra's Thane district has acquitted a 35-year-old man accused of stabbing his nephew, after the victim turned hostile and claimed his injuries were caused by a fall while being intoxicated.

Sessions judge R D Sawant acquitted Arun Bhikaji Pathare, a resident of Uthalsar, of charges under section 307 (attempt to murder) of the Indian Penal Code and provisions of the Arms Act.

As per the case details, the incident occurred on March 25, 2024, when the accused allegedly stabbed Aditya Babu Gaikwad (27) with a kitchen knife.

During the trial, both the victim and his mother, who was the complainant in the



case, failed to support the prosecution.

The judge noted that the victim claimed that he fell and sustained a stomach injury, and hence, the alleged seizure of his clothes with blood stains will not further the prosecution's case.

The court ordered the cancellation of Pathare's bail bonds and directed his acquittal.

Delhi HC gives two weeks to WFI to decide show-cause notice to Vinesh Phogat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday asked the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) to decide within two weeks the show-cause notice issued to grappler Vinesh Phogat over accusations of indiscipline and anti-doping rule violations.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma closed the proceedings on Phogat's petition, which challenged the show-cause notice as well as the WFI's selection policy and circular, after the federation's counsel submitted that her grievance relating to participation in the Asian Games selections trials

was now infructuous. "Within two weeks, decide the show-cause notice dated May 9 under intimation to the petitioner and the court," the judge ordered while disposing of the petition.

The WFI counsel said Phogat would be given a personal hearing before a decision is taken on the notice. Even as Phogat's senior counsel asserted that the petition raised "larger issues" with respect to the selection policy, the court said the athlete would have to file a fresh petition.

"This can be disposed of and then you can file a fresh writ petition," the court said. The court was informed that pursuant to judicial



orders, Phogat was permitted to participate in the Asian Games trials. The petitioner's senior counsel informed that she has received a fresh show-cause notice

for her conduct at the trials.

On May 9, the WFI had issued the show-cause notice to Phogat and declared her ineligible to participate in domestic events till June

26, 2026, citing the mandatory six-month notice period linked to athletes returning from retirement under anti-doping rules.

In her petition, Phogat challenged the WFI's selection policy and circular, which limited eligibility for participation in the Asian Games trials only to medal winners of certain tournaments.

Phogat asserted that the "qualification window" chosen by WFI substantially overlapped with her notified sabbatical on account of pregnancy and postpartum recovery, which created a "closed and inflexible gatekeeping mechanism" that was manifestly arbitrary and discriminatory.

Nitesh Rane appears in court over 2013 case of Goa toll plaza vandalism

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Maharashtra Minister Nitesh Rane appeared before a court in Goa on Monday in connection with the 2013 Dhargal-Pernem toll plaza vandalism and assault case, after a warrant was issued against him for failing to appear in the previous hearing.

Rane, one of nine accused in the case, presented himself before the Judicial Magistrate First Class (JMFC) Court in Mapusa. The minister's counsel informed the court that he had visited the concerned police station on Sunday to furnish a personal bail bond. The court has now



scheduled the matter for final arguments on July 9.

The court had issued a warrant on Saturday after the minister failed to attend the previous hearing. While Rane was absent during proceedings, the other eight co-accused — Rahul Parab, Mukund Parab, Harishchandra Parab, Rakesh Parab, Prashant Malkar,

Vinamra Achrekar, Sagar Patil, and Santosh Raut — appeared before the court.

The case pertains to an incident that occurred on December 3, 2013, following the Goa government's decision to impose a ₹250 entry fee for large vehicles at the Dhargal toll plaza in Pernem taluka.

According to the prosecution, Rane was travelling from Sawantwadi in Maharashtra to Goa's Calangute with his supporters when they encountered the toll facility.

The prosecution has alleged that the group assaulted employees and vandalised the toll booth after being asked to pay the fee.

No relief to Anush, Sudipti from Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday refused to interfere with the non-selection of riders Anush Agarwalla and Sudipti Hajela in India's dressage team for the upcoming Asian Games in Japan.

A bench consisting of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia upheld a previous ruling made by a single judge, which denied relief to Agarwalla and Hajela.

Both riders are gold medal winners from the Asian Games 2022 and filed petitions against the selection decisions made by the Equestrian Federation of India (EFI).



Dismissing the riders' appeals, the bench said that while it did not find any infirmity with the preparation of the list of probabilities, the EFI had failed to duly comply with certain clauses of the selection criteria.

The bench, however, opined that a fresh trial was not possible at this stage and exercised "restraint" in the

larger interest of sports and to avoid any adverse impact on the country's prospects at the Asian Games.

"Having regard to the deadline of July 15, 2026, it is logistically impractical to conduct a further competition within the time frame available, particularly since the riders and horses are located at different places across the globe and transporting horses from different locations to a common venue for conducting a competition amongst all six probabilities would not be possible in such a short span of time," the court said.

The court added that, "We are constrained to refrain from interfering with the impugned judgment."

The supercomputer India borrowed from Japan

America switched off an AI model for 19 days. India’s answer is a supercomputer in Japan — and a bet that indispensability beats sovereignty



NISHANT SAHDEV

Let me tell you about the least glamorous sentence in Indian tech policy this month, and why it might matter more than any product launch you will read about this year.

In the first week of July, on the sidelines of the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, the two Governments signed a Joint Statement on Artificial Intelligence. Buried in the paperwork was a memorandum between Japan’s industry ministry and India’s IT ministry, under which Japan will let Indian researchers use a supercomputer operated by its National Institute of Advanced Industrial Science and Technology. In exchange, India will help ease Japan’s chronic shortage of software engineers. Tokyo has also said it wants to bring 500 highly skilled Indian AI professionals to Japan by 2030. Read quickly, it sounds like the diplomatic equivalent of neighbours lending each other kitchen appliances. You have a mixer-grinder, I have a pressure cooker, let us manage.

Read slowly, it is something else entirely. It is India quietly admitting what kind of AI power it is going to be — and making a bet that most of the world’s loudest voices think is wrong.

The thing nobody says out loud

Here is the uncomfortable arithmetic underneath all of India’s AI ambition. We are a country with more than two million AI-skilled professionals, a technology services industry that industry body Nasscom believes could capture an additional 300 to 400 billion dollars in AI-related business by 2030, and one of the largest pools of software talent on Earth. And we do not have a single frontier AI model of our own.

The chatbots in your phone, the coding assistants in Bengaluru’s offices, the models being wired into banks and hospitals and, increasingly, Government services — the most capable of them are built in San Francisco, Seattle and, lately, Hangzhou. India is the world’s great AI user, not yet its maker. For years, this felt like a comfortable arrangement. Software has always flowed across borders. Why build the expensive thing when you can rent it?

Then June happened.

For nineteen days last month, the American Government ordered one of its leading AI

companies to cut off foreign access to its most advanced model, citing national security. If you were an Indian developer or company that had built your workflow on that model, you woke up one morning and a tool you paid for had simply vanished — not because of a business decision, but because of a memo written in Washington. Access was restored in early July. The lesson was not.

The lesson was this: when you rent your intelligence from someone else, the landlord can change the locks.

Two bad options and a third one

So what is a country in India’s position supposed to do? The debate in Delhi’s policy circles has mostly ping-ponged between two answers, both unsatisfying.

Option one: build everything ourselves. Sovereign models, sovereign chips, sovereign data centres, the works. It is a stirring speech. It is also staggeringly expensive. Training a frontier model now consumes computing power measured in numbers so large they sound invented, and the American companies leading the race are spending more on data centres in a year than India’s entire semiconductor mission — a ₹76,000 crore programme - has committed in total. India’s data centre capacity stands at around 1,280 megawatts



today. That is expected to grow four or five times by 2030, which sounds impressive until you learn that single American AI campuses are being planned at a gigawatt each.

Option two: keep renting and hope for the best. After June, this option should require no further comment.

The Japan pact points at a third answer, and it is the most Indian answer imaginable: be so useful to so many people that nobody can afford to lock you out.

Look at what the deal actually trades. Japan has world-class hardware, precision manufacturing, serious compute infrastructure — and a demographic crisis that has left it desperately short of the software engineers needed to use any of it. India has the exact inverse: an ocean of talent and a shortage of the expensive machinery that talent needs. Japanese officials have spent this year openly describing India as their key partner in the Global South, pairing Indian software scale



with Japanese industrial depth. The supercomputer memorandum is that theory made concrete: our people, their machine.

Notice what India is not doing here. It is not pretending it can outspend Silicon Valley. It is deepening what economists would call backward linkages — securing reliable access to the ingredients of frontier AI (compute, chips, infrastructure) from multiple partners - while building forward linkages for the things India genuinely can make: applications, services, and AI that works in 22 languages for a billion people. The February AI summit in Delhi, the first global AI gathering hosted in the Global South, pushed the same idea with its Trusted AI Commons platform: if you cannot own the frontier, own the friendships.

Is renting sovereignty a bug or a feature?

The obvious criticism writes itself, and it deserves a fair hearing. A borrowed supercomputer is still borrowed. Five hundred engineers going to Japan is, from another angle, five hundred engineers leaving India. Diversifying your dependence across Washington and Tokyo is still dependence; you have merely acquired two landlords instead of one.

All true. And yet.

Consider what dependence actually looks

like in each direction. Japan needs Indian talent so badly that its industrial future partly hinges on it. That is not the relationship of a landlord and a tenant. It is closer to a partnership where each side holds something the other cannot easily replace — which is, historically, the only kind of technology relationship that survives a geopolitical bad mood. The June episode showed what one-sided dependence costs. The Japan deal is an attempt to make sure India’s next dependencies are mutual ones.

There is also a quieter truth here that the sovereignty hawks skip past. The countries that “won” previous technology waves were not always the inventors. South Korea did not invent the semiconductor; it became indispensable to making them. India did not invent the software industry; it became the place the software industry could not function without. Indispensability is a form of sovereignty. It just doesn’t photograph as well as a rocket launch.

What this means for you

If you are reading this in Kolkata or Kanpur rather than a ministry office, here is the honest translation.

In the short term, very little changes. Your chatbot will still be American, your phone’s chips still Taiwanese, and the AI features

creeping into your banking app still built on rented foreign intelligence.

But over the next few years, watch three things. Watch whether Indian researchers actually get meaningful time on that Japanese machine, or whether the memorandum gathers dust the way memoranda do. Watch whether the 500 engineers going to Japan come back — talent that circulates builds a country; talent that only departs builds someone else’s. And watch whether the next time a foreign Government flips a switch on an AI model, Indian businesses shrug instead of panic. That shrug, when it comes, will be the real measure of this strategy.

The loudest voices in AI insist there are only two kinds of countries: those that build the frontier and those that beg at it. India just placed a wager that there is a third kind — the country that makes itself impossible to leave out. It is an unfashionable bet, made in unfashionable paperwork, with no keynote and no applause.

It might also be the shrewdest thing Indian technology policy has done in years. Ask me again in 2030 — preferably over a video call that we can both still trust.

(The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems)

The ‘Chipflation’ crisis: Why AI demand is driving tech price hikes



SHUBHANSH TIWARI

In the recent technological epoch, India’s digital economy is undergoing a rapid transition, working on building a fundamentally strong and completely indigenous AI stack, which powers everything from sovereign language models to hyper-scalable public infrastructure. However, as this technological revolution is closely observed, an underlying crisis threatens to disrupt the momentum. This isn’t an isolated corporate issue; even major tech giants across the globe are aggressively hiking prices to cope with the turbulence caused in the hardware market. A report by Counterpoint Research reveals that the global demand for AI-centric components and hardware has already driven prices of portable computers in India up by 15-20 per cent in early 2026. Most consumers assume that the recent aggressive price hikes on various electronic items, particularly on premium hardware, is just another case of soaring Indian import duties. But this assumption does not stand on the scrutiny of the fact. In reality, we are witnessing the dawn of Chipflation, which is an economic phenomenon, where a massive, demand — driven spike in memory and semiconductor prices surges the cost of consumer electronics and cloud infrastructure. This is no longer a transient market fluctuation but has become a potential threat to India’s economic momentum and a hurdle to our emerging AI infrastructure. Addressing this issue is not optional but is now a baseline prerequisite for India’s survival in the global AI marathon.

India has been witnessing an exponential growth in the consumption and dependence on AI-driven outputs. This shifting landscape has not only increased the demand for services from AI-based companies like OpenAI and Anthropic but has also triggered an immediate requirement for an increase in data storage capacities and a robust cloud infrastructure. The rapid global explosion in the AI infrastructure has triggered



a devastating chain reaction and has now become the root cause of this Chipflation crisis. A recent report by

The Pioneer Artificial Intelligence

The Wall Street Journal, highlights the sheer gravity of Chipflation, revealing that AI data centers are projected to consume almost 70 per cent of all the global memory (DRAM) produced this year. This scarcity has led to the reallocation of resources, primarily chips and semiconductors. The major chip manufacturers are now prioritising the high-margin and high-volume data centre orders. This strategic change in the trend has left a massive void in the consumer electronics market, resulting in severe price volatility.

Despite the severe volatility in the electronic market, the smartphone sector has managed to temporarily evade the price hike. Even major tech giants, which are aggressively increasing the pricing of their portable computers, have left the smartphone industry largely untouched. The secret behind this immunity is actually the result of a visionary industrial policy executed by the Indian Government. Back in 2020, the Government granted Production — Linked Incentive (PLI) benefits to leading tech companies like Samsung and Apple, for the

assembly of smartphones in India. However, this localised assembly is only acting as a buffer against the price shocks caused by hardware. While it shields consumers from immediate import — related tariffs. It offers minimal comfort for India’s digital workforce. This workforce includes all the students, creative professionals and software engineers who form the backbone of our digital economy. These unwanted price hikes are gradually creating a barrier that is causing erosion of purchasing power, making professional tools costlier. This sudden inflation has triggered an unexpected market distortion, the problem does not end after purchasing the overpriced gadget; even the repair and maintenance of the gadget are skyrocketing, making routine maintenance financially crippling.

At heart, the resolution of this pricing crisis will not be found in any correction in the global market scenario, but in a radical shift towards technological self-reliance (*ATMANIRBHARTA*). This hardware scarcity is also resulting in the fast-tracking of the birth of a sovereign Indian cloud infrastructure, which is carving pathways for domestic tech companies to scale up and fulfil the demand for local cloud storage capacities. The Government is constantly working on ways by which the impact of chipflation on the Indian electronic market can be minimised, and the domestic AI stack can be shielded. One of the

(Writer is a research scholar at Manipal University Jaipur)

Why the ability to connect management with technology matters more than ever



DR VINOD VIJAY KUMAR

Let us consider something as simple as changing the price of a product. A retailer increases the price by ten rupees. Demand patterns change and the analytics system detects the shift. The inventory team adjusts its reorder quantity. The logistics team receives a different pickup schedule. A customer expecting delivery on Thursday now receives it on Monday.

It can be seen that one small pricing decision affects many parts of an organisation. This happens because modern organisations are highly interconnected. It is an example of how management and technology interact inside organisations. Today almost every important business decision has both managerial and technological consequences.

Decisions made in one part of an organisation can often influence several others.

Businesses have always depended on specialists. Engineers developed products. Finance teams managed money. Managers coordinated operations.

For much of the last century these groups could work largely on their own. A decision in one department rarely had an immediate impact on several others. However, that situation has changed. Organisations are becoming more connected. Data and digital systems have reduced the boundaries between departments. Work no longer follows traditional organisational boundaries.

Specialists remain important. However, organisations increasingly need people who can connect different areas and bring teams together. They need profes-



sionals who understand both management and technology and can communicate

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Such professionals understand both management and technology. They know how to connect business goals with technological systems. They understand how decisions made in one area influence other parts of the organisation.

They may not be the deepest experts in every field. However, they understand enough to communicate across disciplines. They can interpret analytical results, appreciate technical trade-offs, and explain complex problems in simple terms. Organisations increasingly value analytical thinking, systems thinking, and the ability to bring together knowledge from different domains.

Education is also responding to these changes. Programs that combine management, technology, and analytics are emerging because organisations themselves are changing. Employers increasingly seek graduates who understand markets, systems, and technology. As organisations become more connected, people who understand both management and technology are likely to be in greater demand.

(The writer is an Assistant Professor at the Centre for Technology Foresight and Policy (CTFP), IIT Jodhpur)

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

Indian held in hit-and-run case

An Indian national was arrested on Monday in connection with a hit-and-run incident that killed a 48-year-old person in Nepal's Sudurpaschim Province, police said. An Indian-registered car hit a motorcycle at Boradandi Chowk in Kailali district, killing Padam Chand, according to police. The Indian national fled the scene after the incident but was later arrested by police from Godawari Municipality. He has been identified as Ashwin Kumar Singh, 42, a resident of Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi. Chand was admitted to a local hospital in Dhangadhi, where he died, the police added. Bike driver Gautam Aer, who has sustained injuries in the incident, is undergoing medical treatment at a hospital in Dhangadhi, police said. The police have initiated further investigation into the matter.

PAKISTAN

Officer shot dead in Islamabad

A Pakistan Air Force group captain was shot dead while trying to save a woman from kidnapping in Islamabad, police said on Monday. Group Captain Asim Tariq on Sunday noticed a motorbike rider arguing with a woman and forcing her to ride the bike, with an apparent intention to abduct her near the Shaheen Chowk area of the capital, they said. Tariq, who saw the scene while driving by, stopped his car to intervene, resulting in arguments. The man, identified as Saad Abbasi, flared up, pulled a gun and fired at the officer, who died on the spot, police said. Abbasi, a salesman at a shop, was arrested by police in the evening, they added. President Zardari and PM Shehbaz Sharif expressed deep grief and sorrow over the incident."Sacrificing one's life to protect an innocent woman is a shining example of the highest human values and dedicated service to the nation," Zardari said.

Sea of black-clad mourners fills Tehran streets

NASSER KARIMI/
JON GAMBRELL ■ Tehran

Mourners dressed in black flooded into Iran's Capital Monday for a procession as part of the funeral of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, with throngs of people calling for the death of US President Donald Trump. Khamenei's flag-draped coffin, and those of members of his family killed Feb. 28 in an airstrike at the start of the war launched by Israel and the United States, sat on board a truck decorated to resemble the ornamental grating that surrounds the shrine of an imam. The massive turnout, encouraged by Iran's theocracy as a sign of strength, came as it nego-



Truck carrying the coffins of the slain Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family makes its way through mourners during the funeral procession toward Azadi Tower in Tehran, Iran

tiates with the US over a permanent end to the war that killed the 86-year-old cleric. Helicopter images aired on Iranian state television showed a massive crowd stretching from Tehran's Azadi, or Freedom, Square for kilometers (miles) down a multilane street of the same name. The crowd appeared to be larger than the one that turned out for the 2020 procession for the late Revolutionary Guard General Qassem Solemani, which drew over 1 million people. Authorities offered no immediate crowd count as the truck crept down the street. But people alongside the truck and elsewhere on the route carried placards, signs and banners calling

for Trump's death. "Today that we are here for the funeral for our leader, it's a very tough day," mourner Fatima Hassan said. "We are not here to say goodbye to him, we are here for revenge. And we will take revenge."

Sea of mourners greets Khamenei

Mourners reached out to touch the truck, and some threw scarves and other items for attendants to brush against the coffin, a common practice in Iran seen as a blessing. Attendants, some on the ladders of firetrucks, sprayed misted water across the crowds to cool them in the heat. Authorities appeared concerned about the dangers of having a large crowd along-

side the procession, with officials on loudspeakers urging the public to walk slowly, not to push and to stay to the edges of the street. The coffins will be taken through the streets of Tehran on a 12-hour journey to Mehrabad International Airport, said Revolutionary Guard Gen. Hasan Hasanzadeh, who is overseeing the procession. Authorities have shut down streets, airspace and daily life for the mourning, which began Saturday and will end Thursday as Khamenei is buried at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad, his birthplace. "This is the last time I am seeing him," said a weeping Maryam Alizadeh. "Our generation lived with him for decades." (AP)

Russian missile, drone attack on Ukraine's capital, kills 21

HANNA ARHIROVA/
SAMYA KULLAB
■ Kyiv

Russia unleashed waves of missiles and drones at Ukraine early on Monday, killing at least 21 people in attacks that exposed widening gaps in country's air defences more than four years into Moscow's full-scale invasion, authorities said. All of the ballistic missiles launched by Russia struck their targets, underscoring Kyiv's need for more US-made Patriot interceptor missiles — a point Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy will likely reiterate at a NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, this week. Fifteen people were killed in the capital of Kyiv, which was



A woman taking photo of destructions following Russian missile attacks in Kyiv, Ukraine

Russia's main target, and 56 were injured, according to administrative head Tymur Tkachenko. Another six people were killed in the wider Kyiv region and 21 were injured,

according to Mykola Kalashnyk, the head of the regional administration, and other emergency officials. Emergency workers searched for survivors in the

rubble of residential high-rises in two locations that suffered direct hits. Moscow has stepped up strikes on Kyiv in retaliation for Ukraine's recent long-range strikes, according to the Russian Defense Ministry. Those attacks have caused severe fuel shortages and put pressure on President Vladimir Putin. On Thursday, a Russian strike killed 31 people in Kyiv, the deadliest attack in the capital this year. Ukraine's advances in drone technology have given it an edge in recent months, analysts and Western officials say, striking supply routes behind the front line, stripping the Russian army of momentum on the battlefield and slowing its advance. But Russia is now exploiting a different kind of

momentum: vulnerabilities in Ukraine's air defences, which remain heavily reliant on the Patriot missile systems to intercept ballistic missiles it can rarely shoot down. The war in the Middle East has strained the global supply of Patriot interceptors - a shortage now felt keenly in Ukraine. Ukraine's air force said Russia fired 351 drones and 68 missiles overnight, targeting mainly Kyiv, and all 29 ballistic missiles struck their targets. "To intercept ballistics, we need the means for interception," air force spokesman Yuriy Ihnat said on national television. "Russians are certainly using the fact that there is a serious deficit of interceptor missiles now, in Ukraine and the world." (AP)



China test-fires strategic submarine missile in Pacific

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China on Monday successfully test-fired a long-range strategic missile from one of its nuclear-powered submarines in the Pacific Ocean, drawing sharp reactions from Japan and Australia. The Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) Navy said that one of its nuclear submarines successfully launched a strategic missile carrying a dummy warhead toward the relevant high seas of the Pacific Ocean at 12.01 pm, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. The missile landed precisely within the designated waters, the report said. The test launch is a routine arrangement of the annual training of the PLA Navy, the Navy said, adding that the Chinese side has already notified relevant countries in advance. The test launch complies with international law and international practice, and is not directed at any specific country or target, the Navy said, without identifying the missile and its

range. Japan and Australia, which confirmed they had been given advance notice of the launch, criticised China for the test, saying that it reflected China's heavy military build-up in the region. Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong said the launch was "destabilising to the region." "Australia has been clear that this proposed test is in the context of a rapid military build-up by China, which is lacking in the transparency and reassurance as to intent that the region expects," she was quoted as saying by the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post. "Destabilising acts can lead to miscalculation, can lead where we do not want these actions to lead. I think China is aware of Australia's position," Senator Wong was quoted as saying by the Australian Broadcasting Corporation. "The Pacific Island Forum leaders have made clear they want the Pacific to be an ocean of peace. We regard this proposed test as counter to that." (PTI)

Sri Lanka prison riot death toll rises to 26; 100 injured

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

The death toll in the violent unrest at a prison in Sri Lanka's western coastal town of Negombo has risen to 26, authorities said on Monday. A clash erupted on Sunday between two rival groups of inmates in the over-capacity prison. Clash erupted again on Monday as rioting inmates had grabbed prison guns. Twenty-five people have been killed and over 100 injured as a result of the clashes and subsequent disturbances within the prison, authorities were quoted as saying by the Hiru News. Preliminary findings have revealed that the violence is believed to have erupted between a group allegedly supporting drug trafficking activities within the prison and another group opposed to such activities. Security has been significantly strengthened, with the Police Special Task Force (STF) and riot control units deployed to contain



the situation. Following the clashes, three inmates were transferred to the Pallansena Prison Camp on Monday as part of efforts to restore order and prevent further violence, authorities said. Prisons Department Media Spokesman AC Gajanayake stated that a special investigation has been launched into the incident.

Rutte demands credible NATO defence spending plans

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ankara

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte on Monday demanded that the allies put forward "clear, concrete and credible plans" to reach the organisation's spending targets at its annual summit in Ankara. Rutte made the remarks in the Turkish capital come ahead of a two-day summit starting on Tuesday that comes at a time crucial time for the alliance with the United States scaling down its security role in Europe. Washington has been pressing allies to shoulder more of the spending burden. The 32 nations agreed last year to invest 5 per cent of their gross



Mark Rutte

domestic product on defence - 3.5 per cent on their defence budgets and 1.5 per cent on roads and ports so troops and equipment can move faster in times of conflict. Spain endorsed the goal but said that it could fulfill NATO's security requirements without spending so much. Some countries are still struggling to meet the alliance's old target of 2 per cent of GDP.

Pakistan Army chief Munir vows to secure share under Indus Water Treaty

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's top military brass on Monday resolved to take "all necessary measures" to ensure what it called the country's "rightful share" of water under the Indus Water Treaty. India took a series of punitive measures against Pakistan a day after last year's Pahalgam terror attack on April 22 last year. One of the major steps was putting in "abeyance" the 1960 vintage IWT, which has governed the distribution and use of the Indus river and its tributaries since then. The 276th Corps Commanders' Conference, chaired by Chief of Defence Forces Asim Munir, "expressed resolute commitment to undertake all measures necessary to ensure availability of Pakistan's rightful share of water as per the directives of the Government and



inspirations of the people of Pakistan," the army said in a statement. The forum reaffirmed the guidance given in the National Security Committee (NSC) directive of April 24, 2025, the army said. The NSC meeting held on April

24 last year decided to treat any act of stopping or diverting water as "an act of war." The forum reviewed the prevailing security environment, expressing satisfaction over the operational preparedness, professionalism, and combat readiness of the Pakistan Armed Forces. It expressed "serious concerns over the continued use of territory under the control of the Afghan Taliban regime" by militant groups to carry out attacks inside Pakistan. "Pakistan has an unequivocal right to defend its people from terrorism and the Armed Forces shall continue Intelligence-Based Operations against terrorism emanating from Afghan Taliban controlled territory under the ambit of Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq," it said. The forum also reaffirmed Pakistan's "unyielding diplomatic, political and moral support" to the Kashmiris. (PTI)

Hamas dissolves Gaza Government to transfer power to UN-backed committee

WAFAA SHURAF/
SAMY MAGDY ■ Deir

The Hamas militant group said on Monday it had dissolved its Government in Gaza and is preparing to transfer power to a technical committee backed by the United Nations as part of a US-brokered ceasefire deal. Hamas did not say whether it planned to take the crucial step of disarming or handing over security to an international force, but described its decision as evidence of its commitment to Gaza's reconstruction after years of war. It was unclear if the move, announced by a lower-level official, would



Ismail al-Thawabta

lead to any meaningful change on the ground. The Board of Peace, the new entity led by President Donald Trump with the mandate of governing and rebuilding Gaza, said it was aware of the Hamas announcement but said it

would assess the impact based on "actions, not promises." The board stressed in a statement on X that the technocratic committee must control all weapons in Gaza, as laid out in the ceasefire agreement. At a news conference on

Monday, Ismail al-Thawabta, general director of the Hamas-run Government Media Office, said "only technical and professional staff" would remain in their positions to run the Palestinian enclave's day-to-day affairs. "All employees working in service provision are state employees' and are fully prepared to work under the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza," al-Thawabta said during a press conference in the courtyard of Al-Aqsa Hospital in Deir al-Balah. Hamas spokesperson Hazem Qassem called it "a positive step forward on the path to implement the ceasefire deal." (AP)

Jaishankar meets Bahrain FM, discusses bilateral ties and regional issues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Manama

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met Bahrain's Foreign Minister Abdullah bin Rashid Al Zayani on Monday and discussed deepening bilateral cooperation and ongoing developments in the region. Jaishankar arrived in Bahrain from Qatar on the second leg of this four-nation visit to the Gulf, which also includes Kuwait and Oman, from July 5 to 10. "Delighted to meet FM Dr. Abdullah bin Rashid Al Zayani of Bahrain in Manama today. Discussed deepening our bilateral cooperation.



Jaishankar during a meeting with Bahrain's FM Abdullah bin Rashid Al Zayani in Manama, Bahrain

Exchanged views on ongoing developments in the region," Jaishankar said in a post on X. Jaishankar expressed deep appreciation for Bahrain's role in ensuring the well-being of the Indian community in the country. During the ongoing visit, Jaishankar will meet his counterparts and top leaders of the four Gulf countries to enhance bilateral relations and exchange views on regional developments and issues of mutual interest. The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

Bahrain was under direct Iranian missile and drone strikes before the ceasefire. Qatar and Oman have emerged as mediators, along with Pakistan, in bringing about the Iran ceasefire following weeks of escalating tensions. The indirect talks between the US and Iran in Doha are set to continue after the week-long funeral rites of Iran's slain supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, which started on Friday. During his Qatar visit, Jaishankar met Prime Minister Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani and reviewed cooperation in energy, trade, investments, connectivity and security.

Tanzania arrests dozens ahead of anti-Govt protests

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dar Es Salaam

Tanzanian authorities arrested dozens of people ahead of planned anti-Government protests, part of a crackdown on calls demanding democratic reforms and the release of a key opposition figure. Sylvester Mangure, the army spokesperson, warned Sunday against any demonstrations, following last week's Government ban on political rallies. He also accused "some people," whom he didn't identify, of "recruiting youth" to join the protests as they claimed the



country's army supported the planned demonstrations. Young people have called for protests on Tuesday, coinciding with the 72nd anniversary of the ruling party's establishment, to demand democratic changes and the release of opposition leader Tundu Lissu, who was arrested on treason charges after calling for electoral reforms ahead of last year's general election.

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Gadkari reviews progress of NHLML projects

Union minister Nitin Gadkari on Monday reviewed the project-level progress of multi-modal logistics parks (MMLPs), ropeways, intermodal stations, and wayside amenities being developed across the country. The minister, during a review meeting of the National Highways Logistics Management Ltd (NHLML), emphasised the strategic importance of these transformative initiatives in building a future-ready, integrated transport ecosystem, an official statement said. He noted that these projects will strengthen multimodal connectivity, unlock new economic opportunities, promote balanced regional development, and enhance India's overall logistics competitiveness. Gadkari also evaluated the key challenges affecting project implementation and directed all concerned stakeholders to resolve bottlenecks on priority and expedite project execution. He stated that the timely completion of these projects will improve logistics efficiency, reduce transportation costs, and provide world-class infrastructure and amenities for commuters, further advancing the vision of a Viksit Bharat and an Aatmanirbhar Bharat. (PTI)

GK Energy wins ₹236 crore solar pumping project

GK Energy on Monday said it has secured a ₹235.92-crore order to deploy 10,000 solar-powered water pumping systems across Maharashtra under the Magel Tyala Saur Krushi Pump Yojana. With this project, the company has secured orders worth ₹637.83 crore from the utility, reflecting its strong execution capabilities and continued role in advancing Maharashtra's clean energy transition, an exchange filing said. The order by the Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSDCL), valued at ₹235.92 crore, involves the design, manufacture, supply, transportation, installation, testing and commissioning of 3 HP, 5 HP and 7.5 HP solar-powered agricultural pumping systems across the state. The project will be executed within 60 days from the issuance of the work order/Notice to Proceed (NTP). The initiative will support the deployment of solar-powered irrigation systems across Maharashtra, enabling farmers with reliable and sustainable access to energy for irrigation while reducing dependence on conventional power sources. (PTI)

India can be a connector economy: Anand Mahindra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The next global order may be built by those who can become 'connectors' in a fragmented world, thus creating the opportunity for India to be a 'connector economy' that works across divides, according to Mahindra Group Chairman Anand Mahindra. In his address to shareholders of Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd in the company's latest annual report, Mahindra said global situations that were previously seen as temporary disruptions are now proving to be a more long-term reset of supply chains, geopolitical alignments, and technologies. Mahindra, who last year described the then prevailing global situation "as a 'Samudra Manthan', a churning", said that recent events, particularly in West Asia, are showing the 'Manthan' is far from over. "We have navigated the first churning. We must now brace ourselves for Manthan 2.0. Uncertainty is no longer the exception; it is the rule. Black swan events have become obsolete because the pond is full of black swans," he noted. Stating that there is a shift

from episodic shocks to continuous earthquakes, Mahindra said, "Anticipating change is increasingly difficult, and the imperative is to build the agility and resilience to navigate a constantly shifting landscape. Manthan 2.0 is, indeed, upon us". He, however, expressed confidence that amid the uncertainties, there are opportunities for India to emerge as a significant global player. "The next global order may well be built by those who can become 'connectors' in a fragmented world. This opens up an opportunity for India to be a 'connectoreconomy' that works across divides. It is already beginning to establish this reputation with its low-key 'good-will towards all' approach over

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | JULY 7, 2026

The markets have spoken on E20: Nobody is listening

TUSHAR GUPTA

The debate over E20 petrol in India has a curious structure. On one side: viral videos of engine failures, Twitter threads about rubber seal corrosion, and a rotating cast of automotive commentators warning of civilisational collapse for pre-2023 vehicles. On the other side: five separate markets, each with billions of rupees at stake, showing no distress signal whatsoever. When sentiment and markets diverge this sharply, the question worth asking is not who sounds more convincing — it is who has skin in the game.

Signal One: The used car market is growing, not collapsing

If E20 were quietly destroying pre-2023 vehicles, the segment that constitutes the overwhelming bulk of India's secondhand car inventory, the effect would show up fastest in used car valuations and transaction volumes. Sellers would struggle to offload ageing stock. Buyers would demand steep discounts on vehicles vulnerable to ethanol damage. Platforms would report inventory write-downs and collapsing margins. None of this is happening. Spinnly, one of India's largest organised used-car retailers, posted ₹4,657 crore in revenue for FY25 — a 25 per

cent year-on-year increase — while cutting its net losses by 28 per cent to ₹423 crore. Cars24 India's gross revenue fell to ₹6,233 crore in FY25 from ₹6,910 crore in FY24, according to the company's consolidated financial statements filed with the Registrar of Companies (RoC). The decline was due to operational restructuring and not any market dynamics. Ahead of the IPO, the used-car marketplace claims to have turned profitable for the first time in Q4 FY26, earning ₹20 crore in adjusted EBITDA.

The broader India used-car market was valued at approximately \$41.74 billion in 2026 and is projected to reach \$82.88 billion (some studies place it at around \$70 billion) by 2031, at a CAGR of 14.72 per cent. Another report highlights that 65 per cent of those entering the second-hand car market are first-time owners.

Critically, used cars outnumbered new car sales in FY25: 5.5 million. Most of those 5.5 million units were pre-2023 vehicles — precisely the fleet the E20 panic is centred on. Buyers purchased them anyway, in growing volumes, with full knowledge that E20 was the fuel they would be filling with.

That is not the behaviour of a market pricing in catastrophic risk. If E20 is a problem, as many claim, this should be the first market to collapse.

Signal Two: Auto manufacturers have put service data on the table

The strongest evidence

against the engine-damage narrative came from the manufacturers themselves.

On July 4, 2026, a panel convened by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting brought together representatives from Maruti Suzuki, Hero MotoCorp, Toyota Kirloskar Motor, Hyundai Motor India, Bajaj Auto, and TVS Motors. Maruti Suzuki's Senior Executive Officer (Corporate Affairs), Rahul Bharti, stated that the company serviced 2.84 crore vehicles during FY2025-26, of which more than 1.5 crore were over three years old and not originally E20-certified. His finding: "No cases of corrosion, abnormal wear and tear or reduction in component life attributable to E20 have been reported."

Separately, Maruti data from 1.4 crore E20-run vehicles monitored through service centres over 15 years showed zero evidence of ethanol-induced corrosion.

Hero MotoCorp's Chief Business Officer Ashutosh Varma was equally categorical: "We analyse crores of service data that we have,

and there is no incidence whatsoever of any higher damage with vehicles that run on E20 than the vehicles that were running on fuels before E20."

Hyundai's Associate Vice President Puneet Anand put it more bluntly: "Social media is social media. We have not seen any glaring claims of E20 damage."

Also, manufacturers face shareholder liability and warranty obligations that directly contradict any incentive to hide damage at scale.

However, since many believe the manufacturers to be in cahoots with the government, let's look at what the insurance data is saying, because that will be the first industry to raise alarm bells against claims they had not factored for.

What is the insurance market saying?

If E20 were generating a surge in engine claims, insurance companies would be the first to reprice.

Motor insurance is actuarially driven — insurers do not absorb rising claim frequencies without adjusting premiums or policy exclusions.

Markets surge on 4th day led by bank stocks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Stock markets extended the gaining streak to the fourth day on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex rising by 521 points to settle at a more-than-two-month high, driven by buying in blue-chip bank and oil shares and lower crude oil prices.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 521.16 points, or 0.67 per cent, to settle at 78,285.07, a closing level not seen since April 22. During the day, it surged 634.15 points, or 0.81 per cent, to 78,398.06.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 159.50 points, or 0.66 per cent, to end at 24,430.35, the highest closing level since April 21.

In four consecutive trading days, the BSE benchmark has jumped 1,806.4 points, or 2.36 per cent, and the Nifty by 564.6 points, or 2.36 per cent.

Fresh foreign fund inflows aided the optimistic trend in the domestic equity market, analysts said. Foreign institutional investors bought equi-

ties worth ₹1,355.33 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

Among the Sensex pack, HDFC Bank climbed the most by 3.59 per cent. Mahindra & Mahindra, Bharat Electronics, Reliance Industries, ICICI Bank, and Maruti were also among the winners.

Kotak Mahindra Bank, Tata Consultancy Services, Bajaj Finserv, and Power Grid were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 0.82

per cent to \$71.53 per barrel.

"Indian equities traded with a positive bias despite mixed global cues, supported by stable crude prices. Continued softness in crude would support inflation, the current account balance, OMC profitability, and overall macro stability," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

Broader markets also advanced as the BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.71 per cent and SmallCap

Select index went up by 0.47 per cent.

Sectorally, Realty jumped the most by 1.82 per cent, followed by MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (1.40 per cent), Private Banks Index (1.50 per cent), Top 10 Banks (1.24 per cent), Capital Goods (1.19 per cent) and Auto (1.14 per cent). IT, Utilities, PSU Bank, Focused IT and Services were the laggards.

"Markets maintained their upward bias despite mixed global cues, driven by buying in select banking, auto, capital goods and realty shares. The calmness in the West Asia region and hopes for a relatively steady corporate earnings season kept investor mood optimistic, although overall sentiment remains cautious," Ankur Punj, MD & Business Head at Equirus Wealth, said.

Globally, profit-booking in crowded AI-led trades impacted the global market while India could perform well led by large caps due to improvement in FII inflows trend, he added.

BUSINESS

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The market has done neither. The Government clarified that motor insurance policies remain valid for E20 use, and there is no publicly available data showing any insurer has issued a blanket E20-exclusion clause on older vehicles.

Further, motor policies, if one reads the fine print, only cover accidental damage, theft, and natural disasters. Therefore, to assume that they will single out E20 and refuse to pay for engine damage due to maintenance issues is a baseless assumption.

Insurance is where the real money is. If the companies saw a risk, it would show up in the premiums. As of today, it isn't.

The logistics argument against multiple blends

The counter-proposal circulating online — offer E0 alongside E20 and let consumers choose — sounds reasonable until you run the numbers.

India has over 1,00,266 petrol pumps as of November 2025, with IOC leading at 41,664 outlets, BPCL at 24,605, and HPCL at 24,418.

Even IOC's XP100, a 100-octane ethanol-free premium grade, is available only at select metro outlets — launched initially in 10 cities, with XP95 covering roughly 12,000-13,000 of IOC's outlets at rollout. High-octane variants exist at a small fraction of total pumps because they serve a niche.

Maintaining dual ethanol-blend infrastructure across 1 lakh pumps would require separate underground

storage tanks, separate tanker fleets, separate supply chains, and separate inventory accounting — while drawing on a single agricultural feedstock (ethanol) that is seasonal, crop-dependent, and geographically concentrated.

Regular petrol and diesel already account for approximately 93-95 per cent of India's total fuel sales. The economics of investing in parallel infrastructure for the remaining margin — catering to a risk that no market is pricing in — do not survive scrutiny.

Also, the E0 blend will be about catering to a fleet that is going to be obsolete in ten years, or perhaps fifteen. The question is whether a significant threshold (say 20 per cent) of those owners will be willing to cough up extra money for the same volume of fuel? What if they don't? What if it's a niche?

In that case, the OMCs may want to consider having a few pumps with the variant, but it will be an economic choice, based on the latest market dynamics they have access to. Even the best anecdotes fail that test.

Sentimental chatter can often drown out the reality outside social media. This is where the market and its invisible hand offer some perspective. The signs are there, crystal clear.

There's a fiscal argument and energy security angle to explore, but that's for another day.

The writer is a senior political journalist, covering politics, economy, and technology. He is also the editor of PolityPolicy

Rupee falls 20 paise to close at 95.38 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated 20 paise to close at 95.38 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, as a strengthening greenback weighed on emerging market currencies.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.25 against the American currency and traded in a range of 95.22-95.48 during the session.

The rupee finally closed at 95.38 (provisional), down 20 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee appreciated 17 paise to close at 95.18 against the US dollar.

"Indian rupee declined as the US Dollar firmed up, as markets continue to price in one rate hike this year. However, positive domestic markets and weakness in the crude oil prices supported the rupee," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Choudhary further added that "hedging demand from importers may cap sharp upside. Traders may take cues from ISM services PMI data from the US. \$/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.10 to 95.60."

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 101.12, up 0.26 per cent.

Auto industry total retail sales rise 21.83% in June: FADA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Total automobile retail sales in India grew by 21.83 per cent year-on-year at 25,57,234 units in June, with the industry remaining cautiously optimistic going forward hoping for monsoon to make up for the deficit, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said on Monday.

In June last year total automobile retail sales in India stood at 20,98,996 units, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said in a statement. Passenger Vehicles (PV) retail sales were at 4,10,853 units last month as compared to 3,19,412 units in June 2025, a growth of 28.63 per cent, it added. Two-wheelers sales were at

18,28,458 units in June this year as compared to 15,08,378 units in the same month a year ago, at a growth of 21.22 per cent, it added.

FADA further said three-wheeler sales stood at 1,20,889 units last month as compared to 1,04,035 units in June 2025, up 16.2 per cent.

Suzuki-backed Next Bharat Ventures announces ₹2,000 cr impact fund

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Japan's Suzuki Motor Corporation-backed Next Bharat Ventures IFSC Pvt Ltd on Monday announced the launch of its second fund of ₹2,000 crore, aimed to support startups across sectors, including agriculture, financial inclusion, healthcare and AI for social good in India.

Earlier, through its first ₹340 crore fund, Next Bharat Ventures (NBV) invested in over 20 'impact organisations'. The second fund will mostly come from Suzuki Motor Corporation

as the anchor LP but there will be other money which will also be raised from other corporations from Japan, Next Bharat Ventures Founder and CEO Vipul Jindal Nath told PTI. Asked what in areas the fund will be deployed, he said, "The sectors which we invest in are basically any sector where a startup can help (improve) the quality of life for the local communities of rural India, tier two-three towns, or even in big cities (those of) informal and gig economy workers."

It automatically becomes like agriculture, agritech, healthcare, health-tech and

livelihood, Nath added.

On the timeline for the deployment of the fund, he said, "We will be deploying the ₹2,000 crore in the next three to four years."

On the reason for raising

almost the entire corpus from Japan, Nath said, "Because we believe Japanese institutions are much more patient in terms of investment."

Unlike a typical VC fund, he

said, "Our fund cycle is not 12 years, it is 15 years because the kind of investment we make in the sector, the impact, they need a little bit more (time). The speed is not exponential growth or hyper growth curve, (it needs) more time, more patience, and we want to give that to them."

This second corpus will enable Next Bharat Ventures to significantly expand its support towards "impact entrepreneurs" building to improve quality of life and sustainable livelihoods across rural India and migrated and urban marginalised communities, the company said.

PROSPECT

Integrated yoga training event held in Kamrup

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Under the initiative of PM Shree Gaonwe Gaonwe Jog Maha Abhijan, an 11-day integrated yoga training programme was organised in Kamrup district. The valedictory programme was held on Monday at the Conference Hall of the Integrated DC Office, Amingaon, where the District Commissioner, Kamrup, Deba Kumar Mishra, presented certificates of appreciation to the trainers in recognition of their contribution to the successful conduct of the programme. He subsequently distributed certificates to the participants who successfully completed the training.

Addressing the gathering, the District Commissioner highlighted the growing acceptance of yoga across the country under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. He informed the gathering that the initiative was launched by the Governor



of Assam, Lakshman Prasad Acharya, on June 21, 2026, at Gandhi Ashram, Sualkuchi. Referring to the historical significance of the venue, he noted that Mahatma Gandhi had visited the renowned silk weaving town on January 9, 1946, making it a fitting location for the launch of the initiative.

The District Commissioner urged schools and colleges to actively promote awareness about the benefits of yoga among students and the wider community.

The programme was also attended by Additional District Commissioner (Health) Monika Borgohain; CM&HO; District Nodal Officer, AYUSH Mission; DPM (NHM) and other concerned officials.

World Rural Development Day 2026: VB-GRAMG marks new chapter in rural transformation



ALTAF HUSSAIN HAJI

Every year on **6 July**, the world observes **World Rural Development Day**, an international observance recognized by the United Nations General Assembly to reaffirm the importance of improving the lives and livelihoods of rural communities. The day highlights the urgent need to eradicate rural poverty, strengthen food security, promote gender equality, encourage digital inclusion, and build climate-resilient communities—all of which are essential to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

For India, where nearly two-thirds of the population continues to depend directly or indirectly on rural livelihoods, the observance carries special significance. Sustainable rural development is not merely a social objective but an economic necessity for building an

inclusive and prosperous nation.

Against this backdrop, the Government of India has launched the **Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-GRAMG)** from **July 2026**, with revised implementation guidelines aimed at accelerating rural development. The mission seeks to generate productive employment, reduce rural poverty, strengthen food security, improve rural infrastructure, empower women, and promote climate-resilient development through transparent and technology-driven governance.

A key objective of VB-GRAMG is the creation of durable community assets that simultaneously generate employment and improve the quality of life in villages. Investments in rural roads, irrigation facilities, water conservation structures, and village infrastructure are expected to enhance agricultural productivity, reduce seasonal migration, and strengthen local economies.

The mission also recognizes that food security depends on sustainable man-



agement of natural resources. Activities such as watershed development, rainwater harvesting, soil conservation, and sustainable farming practices are expected to improve farm productivity while protecting the environment for future generations.

Women remain central to the mission's vision. VB-GRAMG encourages greater participation of women in rural employment, supports women-led Self-Help Groups (SHGs), promotes equal wages and equal opportunities, and strengthens livelihood initiatives that enhance women's economic indepen-

dence. Greater participation of women in the rural economy contributes not only to gender equality but also to stronger families and more resilient communities. Climate resilience forms another important pillar of the programme. Through afforestation, land development, drought mitigation, water conservation, and ecosystem restoration, the mission aims to help rural communities adapt to climate change while preserving natural resources for sustainable development.

Equally significant is the emphasis on digital gover-

nance. Digital attendance, Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT), online monitoring, and technology-enabled project management are expected to improve transparency, accountability, and timely delivery of benefits to eligible rural households.

The objectives of VB-GRAMG closely reflect the spirit of World Rural Development Day. Both emphasise poverty reduction, sustainable livelihoods, food security, gender equality, digital inclusion, climate resilience, and quality rural infrastructure. Together, these priorities support India's commitment to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals while advancing the vision of Viksit Bharat.

As the nation observes World Rural Development Day, initiatives such as VB-GRAMG demonstrate that rural development is not merely about creating infrastructure—it is about empowering people, strengthening communities, and ensuring that economic progress reaches every village. A prosperous India can only be built on the foundation of

prosperous villages, where every rural citizen has access to opportunities, dignity, and sustainable livelihoods.

If implemented effectively, VB-GRAMG has the potential to become a transformative milestone in India's journey towards inclusive, resilient, and sustainable rural development goals.

India can build stronger villages and improve rural livelihoods by investing in people, natural resources, rural infrastructure, and digital governance. The successful implementation of the Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission Gramin (VB-GRAMG) has the potential to become a transformative milestone in realising the vision of Viksit Bharat through inclusive and sustainable rural development. By creating employment opportunities, strengthening local economies, and promoting equitable growth, the mission can help build a resilient and prosperous rural India where no citizen is left behind.

The writer is Deputy Director General (DDG) & Statistical Advisor, Department of Rural Development, MORD Government of India

CBI arrests NHA project director, two others in ₹12-lakh bribery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has arrested the project director of the National Highways Authority of India (NHA), Shillong, and two private persons for allegedly demanding ₹12 lakh from a contractor for clearing his pending bill.

The central agency had registered a case on July 1 based on a complaint alleging that NHA project director Aanand Singh Chouhan "demanded bribe/undue advantage of ₹12 lakh from the complainant to process his outstanding bill to the tune of ₹13.38 crore", an official statement said.

According to the statement, the accused official instructed the complainant to pay an advance of ₹4 lakh as part of the alleged bribe



and asked him to hand over the money to a private person in Guwahati.

"The said private person in turn asked the complainant to hand over the bribe to another private person at Guwahati," the CBI said. The agency said it laid a trap and "caught the accused private person red-handed while demanding and accepting bribe/undue advantage of

₹4 lakh from the complainant".

Following the trap, the project director and both the private persons — Punet Agarwal and Manish Agarwal — were arrested, while searches were conducted at their respective premises, the CBI said.

Further investigation into the matter is underway, it added.

US Triple-C 2026 and Canada Triple-C 2026 online cryptic crossword challenge kick off

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna/New Delhi

History was created on Sunday 5th as the first-ever US Triple-C 2026 Crossword Challenge and Canada Triple-C 2026 Crossword Challenge commenced simultaneously with their Practice Round, marking a significant milestone in the global promotion of competitive cryptic crosswords.

The inaugural edition witnessed an overwhelming response from crossword enthusiasts across America and Canada, reflecting the growing popularity of cryptic crosswords and the success of the initiative in bringing together participants on a common international platform.

One of the most remarkable highlights of the US



Paolo Pasco (US)

Triple-C 2026 Practice Round was that the Top 10 scorers represented 10 different states of the USA, namely New York, Missouri, Oregon, Connecticut, Virginia, Maryland, Texas, Mississippi, Virginia, California an extraordinary and unique achievement that showcased the widespread reach of the championship and the depth of crossword talent across the country.

The US Triple-C 2026 –



Will Nediger (Canada)

Practice Round Winners were Paolo Pasco from New York, Erik Agard based at Missouri and Matthew Theodore Marcus of Oregon.

While the Canada Triple-C 2026 – Practice Round Winners were Will Nediger hailing from Ontario, Daniel Currie Hall of Nova Scotia and Rupert Marten Morris also from Ontario.

The championships were organised by Extra-C, committed towards creating

crossword awareness globally and WCWF (World Crossword Federation) with the support of Bihar Tourism, whose encouragement has played a vital role in taking this unique intellectual initiative to an international audience and Bihar Foundation and Bihar-Jharkhand Association of North America (BJANA).

With the successful completion of the Practice Round, participants now look forward to the main championship. The First Online Round will be held on 12th July 2026, followed by the Second Online Round on 19th July 2026. The final results and championship winners will be announced on 26th July 2026, according to a Press release from the organisers.

Gold overtakes vehicle loans as top securitised asset class in Q1 FY'27: CRISIL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Gold loans emerged as the largest securitised asset class in the April-June quarter of the current fiscal, overtaking vehicle loans in the country's securitisation market, a report said on Monday.

Securitisation, a process through which lenders pool loans and sell them to investors to raise funds and free up capital for fresh lending, saw issuances surge 22 per cent year-on-year to around ₹60,000 crore in the April-June quarter, a CRISIL Ratings report said. The report said more than 98 per cent of issuances during quarter were originated by non-banking financial companies (NBFCs).

DAILY SUDOKU

		8		4		7		
6								
		9	8	5		4		
1				9			4	7
9		4				8		3
8	7			6				5
		6			2	7	3	
								8
2		1			9			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

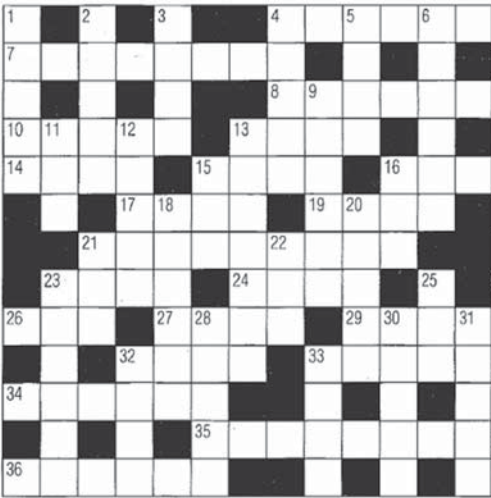
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (6.7.26)								
2	3	7	5	1	8	9	6	4
8	9	6	7	3	4	1	5	2
5	4	1	2	9	6	7	3	8
6	2	3	1	8	9	5	4	7
4	8	5	6	7	2	3	9	1
1	7	9	4	5	3	8	2	6
7	5	4	3	6	1	2	8	9
9	1	2	8	4	5	6	7	3
3	6	8	9	2	7	4	1	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | JULY 7, 2026



ACROSS

- 4 They enable you to see a slight possibility (6)
- 7 That romantically remembered ash blonde? (3,5)
- 8 The smooth stuff you're lucky to be on (10)
- 10 A rambler came up (5)
- 13 At the boxing match, what one hears from the church? (4)
- 14 A brolly with character (4)
- 15 School of royal equeuries (4)
- 16 Allowed to run out (3)
- 17 Being stony, is only able to give a friend love (4)
- 19 Swing round in ever changing direction (21)
- 21 To appear advanced, use foresight (4,5)

DOWN

- 1 A letter or two from a Scotswoman (5)
- 2 I had one order in the vernacular (5)
- 3 It could be the size used by decorators (4)
- 4 To be honest, a woman surrounded by wealth (5)
- 5 A measure of good and bad (4)
- 6 A sweeter rhyme to amuse well-balanced children (6)
- 9 Twin ones can form a team (6)
- 11 Lacking refinement, a bit of a tearaway (3)
- 12 It'll hold a little food, maybe as bait (5)
- 13 The rest may be in the bank (7)
- 15 Chat a girl up? (3)
- 16 Left a fellow behind (3)

- 23 Spanish party for Poles? (4)
- 24 They're good, but they don't take orders (3)
- 26 In no way historic or futuristic (3)
- 27 Diplomacy used in taking volunteers to court (4)
- 29 One side of a tea strainer (4)
- 32 Powerful force taking a convict back east (4)
- 33 It grows, somewhat like sage (5)
- 34 The last thing one may want to hear at a concert (6)
- 35 Just the bird to ring us when hungry (8)
- 36 Obtained from the branch at the end of the street (6)

- 18 Such an order, one can send to a pupil (6)
- 20 It can lend support to an artist's views (5)
- 21 Owl fluttering close to the ground (3)
- 22 A little house in South Utrecht (3)
- 23 Muddled in mood, takes part in a game (6)
- 25 In practice, stirred by a rod going round (3)
- 28 Ready for a drink and a bit of sport (5)
- 30 So Dai contrived to say farewell! (5)
- 31 That Euro rubbish you may have seen on TV? (5)
- 32 The boys joke about the new head (4)
- 33 Still, there's satisfaction in getting it (4)

Kaziranga University announces new development vision for Assam and North-East

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Kaziranga University on Monday unveiled an ambitious roadmap to position itself as a strategic knowledge and innovation partner in the transformation of Assam and the North-East through globally connected education, cutting-edge research, entrepreneurship and industry collaboration.

Basant Khetan, Pro Chancellor of Kaziranga University, said the University is entering a new phase of institution building that aligns with the aspirations of Viksit Assam and Viksit Bharat 2047. "The future of universities lies beyond awarding degrees. Universities must become engines of innovation, entrepreneurship, skill develop-



ment and societal transformation. Our vision is to build Kaziranga University into a nationally respected institution that empowers youth, strengthens communities and contributes directly to the sustainable development of Assam and the North-East."

The Pro Chancellor observed that Assam is experiencing one of the most significant periods of development in its

history. Massive investments in infrastructure, healthcare, digital connectivity, logistics, advanced manufacturing and sustainable development are transforming the State into India's gateway to the East.

He noted that the expanding strategic partnership between India and Japan, together with increasing global interest in the North-East, is expected to create unprecedented opportunities in sectors such as sustainable agriculture, silk and sericulture, food processing, river and water management, flood resilience, biodiversity, climate adaptation, advanced manufacturing, semiconductors, artificial intelligence and future technologies. Kaziranga University believes that the greatest beneficiaries of this transformation should be the

youth of Assam. The University announced several strategic initiatives that demonstrate its commitment to translating vision into measurable outcomes.

Among the major initiatives are: ₹1 Crore KU Startup Fund to nurture student-led innovation and entrepreneurship. ₹3 Crore Scholarship Programme to ensure that deserving students are not denied quality education due to financial constraints. Dr M L Gaur, Vice Chancellor, outlined the University's academic roadmap. With over 41 years of multifaceted professional experience, Dr Gaur has served premier research institutions, agricultural and private universities in diverse leadership positions including Scientist, Professor, HoD, Dean, Founder Principal and Vice Chancellor.

Kerala Police warn against fake Flipkart GOAT sale scams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Police on Monday warned the public against a new cyber fraud in which scammers are using fake social media pages and advertisements in the name of Flipkart's "GOAT" Sale to cheat people. In a statement, the police said fraudsters have created fake Facebook pages resembling official Flipkart accounts using names such as "Flipkart GOAT SALE", "Goat Sale Live", "Offers Sale" and "FK Goats Offer's" to lure unsuspecting customers.

The fake pages advertise expensive products such as mobile phones, laptops and other electronic gadgets at unusually low prices to attract buyers. Users clicking on the advertisements are redirected either to fake websites designed to resemble Flipkart's official portal or to private WhatsApp numbers. The scammers then create a false



sense of urgency through messages claiming "limited stock" or that the offer is about to end, and persuade customers to transfer money as booking charges, advance payments, delivery fees or offer confirmation charges.

After receiving the money, the fraudsters either fail to deliver the products, demand additional payments, or become unreachable, the statement said.

The police advised the public not to trust offers circulated through social media platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, WhatsApp and Telegram without proper verification.

Consumers should verify the authenticity of offers only through Flipkart's official mobile application or website and should avoid making payments or sharing personal information through links received on social media.

People were also advised not to transfer money to unknown bank accounts or UPI IDs and never to share confidential information such as OTPs, bank account details, debit or credit card numbers, CVV or PIN with anyone. The police cautioned that advertisements offering costly products at prices far below the prevailing market rate are often traps laid by cyber fraudsters and urged people to verify the authenticity of such offers through official platforms before making any purchase. Victims of online financial fraud should immediately report the incident by calling the national cybercrime helpline 1930 or by filing a complaint through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, the police said.

BRIEFLY

Brazil left to second-guess penalty kick choice after earliest WC exit since 1990



Vinicius Junior had the ball at the penalty spot, a perfect chance to give Brazil the lead. And he handed it to Bruno Guimarães. And by the time Neymar – in what he said was his final World Cup appearance – took and made Brazil's second penalty kick, it was too late for the five-time champion.

Guimarães had his penalty shot stopped by Årjan Nyland in the 14th minute and Brazil couldn't get one past Norway's goalkeeper until deep in stoppage time, losing 2-1 on Sunday in the round of 16 for its earliest World Cup exit since 1990.

"We just have to apologize to the Brazilian people, to everyone that attended this venue and witnessed this match, and I think we have to learn from our mistakes," Brazil captain Marquinhos said. "For those that come in the new generation, I ask that the people will support them from the beginning." The Brazilians will be left with four years of second-guessing, wondering why they chose not to have one of soccer's elite scorers take the penalty shot after Cunha was taken down by sliding tackle in box. (AP)

After Asia's World Cup stumble, resignations pile up from Seoul to Riyadh



The fallout in Asian football continues as the continent comes to terms with an underwhelming World Cup performance. On Monday, Chung Mong-gyu stepped down as president of the Korea Football Association.

His departure follows harsh criticism from the country's president and the resignation of coach Hong Myung-bo last week after South Korea's group-stage exit that culminated in a 1-0 loss to South Africa.

"There were moments when I lived up to expectations and moments when I left you deeply disappointed," said Chung, who has held the role since 2013. "All the success is thanks to our players and fans, and all the mistakes are my responsibility. "I am convinced that Korean football will overcome adversity and reach great heights once again, as it always has." South Korea's soccer superstar Son Heung-min apologised for the team's performance in a long social media post where he said he was "indiscribably hurt" and eager to "win the hearts" of the nation once again. (AP)

Haaland scores twice to beat Brazil, send Norway into WC quarterfinals

STEPHEN WHYNO
■ East Rutherford (US)

Erling Haaland scored, and Andreas Schjelderup jumped on his teammate's back. Haaland scored again, and Schjelderup leapt up again.

Heading in the go-ahead goal in the 79th minute and scoring again before the end of regulation time, Haaland put Norway on his back and carried it into the World Cup quarterfinals for the first time with a 2-1 defeat of Brazil on Sunday that showcased the towering striker on soccer's biggest stage.

"Maybe this will write history in Norway," Haaland said. "Everyone just need to enjoy themselves. This is just an insane day. It's one of the most insane days in Norwegian history. Just enjoy



it, embrace it and enjoy the moment." After being a non-factor for much of the afternoon and having limited touches, Haaland spoke at the second-half hydration break with coach Stale Solbakken, who told him to drain his energy and go for it.

Haaland turned it on when it mattered most, getting the right side of his head on the

Norway.

At the other end, goalkeeper Årjan Nyland was stellar. He made a crucial stop early, diving to his left to deny Bruno Guimarães' penalty kick in the 14th minute, then got his left hand on a shot by Endrick late when Norway was hanging on to a one-goal lead.

The only goal Nyland allowed was to Neymar on a penalty kick late in stoppage time, which changed just the final score. Neymar, who is 34, said this was his final game playing for Brazil's national team.

Nyland, who at 35 is his team's oldest player, was a huge factor in a historic victory that ranks among the most significant in the country's history – at least on the men's side. Norway's women's team won the World Cup in 1995, but the men have only qualified four times and not since 1998. They had not gone further than round of 16. (AP)



Mexico's World Cup run ends short of quarterfinals again



CARLOS RODRIGUEZ
■ Mexico City

Mexico had an enormous home-field advantage and an opportunity to make its deepest run in the World Cup, but El Tri let it slip away against England on Sunday night.

Playing at altitude with the passionate backing of 80,824 fans at Estadio Azteca, and with a man advantage for most of the second half, Mexico scored twice but could never equalize and lost 3-2.

Mexico hadn't conceded a goal in its first four World Cup matches but had no answer for Jude

Bellingham, who scored twice in a 98-second span in the first half.

"To dream and then fall like this hurts deeply, but the players should leave with their heads held high," coach Javier Aguirre said. "They

gave it their all on the pitch, but it wasn't meant to be today. The fans had high hopes, and we couldn't get the job done and give them another night of joy."

While El Tri made a step forward from their group-stage exit in Qatar in 2022, the defeat leaves a bitter taste for Mexico fans who were hoping to see their country's first quarterfinal appearance since 1986, when it last hosted the World Cup. Mexico has been eliminated in the round of 16 eight times since then.

"We played against a strong team in an amazing



stadium, in an amazing country. I feel almost to say sorry that you (Mexicans) are out after seeing all the emotion from the people on the side of the street. You should be proud of your team," England manager Thomas Tuchel said.

Aguirre will step down after his third stint as Mexico's coach. Rafael Marquez, a former Barcelona defender, who was Aguirre's assistant at this World Cup, will replace him.

"These five matches are unforgettable. I am saying goodbye to the Estadio Azteca and leaving with great pride after so many years," Aguirre said. "Rafa is a great kid, a valuable coach and he is going to show it. Hopefully he is going to do it better than me."

It was Mexico's third competitive loss at Azteca, which opened in 1966, after a pair of 2-1 defeats in World Cup qualifiers, to Costa Rica in 2001 and to Honduras in 2013. (AP)

Ronaldo says World Cup with Portugal will be his last



SCHUYLER DIXON
■ Arlington (US)

Cristiano Ronaldo's sometimes playful banter in a rare World Cup news conference ended in an exchange between Portugal's superstar and a reporter from Argentina.

Ronaldo took the moment on the eve of a round of 16 clash with border rival Spain to repeat something he has said at least once before.

This sixth World Cup for the former Manchester United and Real Madrid star will be his last.

"What remains with me is the people – the people who love you. I share hotels with the staff, Latino people, and those are spectacular memories. Yesterday on the flight, there was an Argentine flight attendant. And knew she was Argentine by the way she looked at me: I knew you were Argentine by the way you looked at me. If you look away quickly, it means you don't like Cristiano,"

Ronaldo said in translated remarks Sunday, breaking into a smile.

"I want to enjoy what will be my last World Cup to the fullest," Ronaldo continued. "Hopefully, tomorrow won't be my last match. That way, you can keep bashing me some more."

Ronaldo, the career leader in international goals with 146, made similar comments in a television interview late last year, a few months after Portugal won the UEFA Nations League title with a riveting victory over Spain in a penalty shootout. Many of the questions for the 41-year-old during a 25-minute session at the home of the NFL's Dallas Cowboys referred to what everybody in the packed room was assuming: This was it for Ronaldo.

Before the end, he joked with reporters that they were pushing him out the door. Just about every time he did, though, he would turn philosophical. (AP)

US seeks revenge for thrilling World Cup loss to Belgium 12 years ago

ANDREW DESTIN ■ Seattle

When Belgium goalkeeper Thibaut Courtois reflected on the last time his side faced the United States in the World Cup, Tim Howard came to mind.

Courtois was in net opposite one of the greatest American goalies, who made 16 saves in a 2-1, extra time loss to Belgium at the 2014 World Cup in Brazil. Though Howard has long since hung up his boots, the 34-year-old Courtois will start again on



Monday when the US plays Belgium in the round of 16.

Since that thrilling match over a decade ago, American soccer has

made significant strides.

"I think they can produce a lot of talent and become a world force," Courtois said. "They're already a great team together, they play well. So I think that's a good evolution, and they're showing it this World Cup.

Hopefully it comes to an end (Monday) and that we can win, but we're expecting a tough game." The World Cup has excited soccer fans and piqued many Americans' interest, even as the sport continues to strive toward achieving mainstream popularity in the United States. There have been setbacks since that Belgium game 12 years ago, including a stunning loss to Trinidad and Tobago in 2017 that led to the U.S. missing the 2018 World Cup in Russia.

Led by Argentine coach Mauricio Pochettino, who has embraced the American experience this summer, U.S. is one win away from advancing as far as it ever has at the World Cup. The Americans have won three of four games in the tournament with a roster featuring stars from European clubs. (AP)

The OCI opportunity: A boost for Indian football but far from a magic wand



SHAKYA MITRA

Few sporting debates have gathered as much momentum in recent times as the possibility of allowing those holding Overseas Citizenship of India (OCI) to represent India through a proposed sports passport without having to give up the citizenship of their original country. The discussion, which has been ongoing for some time, has gathered pace during the 2026 FIFA World Cup as fans watched several smaller footballing nations punch above their weight by drawing upon players developed overseas. For a country that has never played at the FIFA World Cup despite a population of over 1.4 billion, the question naturally arises, why not India?

The answer is yes, but with an important caveat. If India eventually opens

the door to OCI athletes in football, it should be viewed as an opportunity to strengthen the national team, not as a convenient substitute for addressing the structural deficiencies that have held Indian football back for decades.

The appeal of the diaspora model is easy to understand. Cape Verde and Curaçao, both making their World Cup debuts in 2026, demonstrated how countries with relatively small populations can leverage their overseas communities to compete on the biggest stage. Cape Verde's memorable run to the knockout stage, where they pushed three-time champions Argentina all the way, was a reminder that modern international football is no longer confined by geography.

There is nothing unusual about this approach. FIFA's eligibility rules have long allowed players to represent countries through their parents or grandparents, provided they meet the governing body's nationality requirements. The question for India is whether its own citizenship framework should evolve to make greater use of



that opportunity.

Morocco are a strong benchmark. Their remarkable run to the semi-finals in Qatar four years ago was no one-off, and they have once again emerged as one of the standout teams at the 2026 World Cup. What often goes unnoticed is that 19 of the 26 players in Morocco's current squad were born outside the country. Many came through elite academies in France, Belgium, Spain and the Netherlands before opting to represent Morocco through their family roots.

Even within Asia, Indonesia have

embraced a similar strategy. Having last played at the World Cup in 1938 as the Dutch East Indies, they have actively recruited players of Indonesian descent born and raised in the Netherlands. Although they missed out on qualification for the expanded 2026 World Cup, their long-term direction is unmistakable.

Recent policy discussions suggest India could look to follow a similar route. If there are footballers of Indian origin playing in top overseas leagues who qualify under FIFA regulations, then the national team should certainly look at tapping them. Higher-quality players increase internal competition, improve training standards and expose younger footballers to professional habits acquired in stronger footballing environments.

But this is where comparisons with Morocco or Indonesia must be made carefully.

Morocco's diaspora is concentrated in countries with world-class football ecosystems, while Cape Verde, Curaçao and Indonesia have long-standing

migration links with Portugal and the Netherlands respectively. India, by contrast, currently has only a handful of quality players competing at the highest levels in Europe who could realistically qualify under FIFA's eligibility rules through parentage or grandparentage.

More importantly, no diaspora policy can compensate for weaknesses at home.

Indian football continues to face significant structural challenges, including inconsistent grassroots programmes, limited youth competitions and fragile club structures. These are not problems that can be solved by adding a few overseas-born footballers to the national squad. National teams are ultimately reflections of the systems beneath them. Without improving that foundation, any gains from OCI inclusion are likely to be incremental rather than transformational.

The debate also raises wider questions beyond football. India has built competitive programmes in sports such as wrestling, badminton, hockey

and cricket, while its Olympic performances have steadily improved despite the country never winning more than 10 medals at a single Games. While reports suggest the proposed OCI eligibility is primarily intended for sports such as football, tennis and basketball, if it is eventually expanded to all sports, policymakers will have to carefully balance the short-term advantages of overseas-born talent against the long-term objective of developing athletes within India itself. That balancing act is crucial. No aspiring football nation has succeeded solely because it tapped into its diaspora.

If the policy is eventually introduced, it should be welcomed as an important addition towards the growth of Indian football. It can make the national team stronger, deepen the talent pool and raise professional standards. What it cannot do is replace sustained investment in academies, coaching, competitions and governance. Those remain the real determinants of whether India will one day qualify for its first FIFA World Cup.

Bishnoi set to be dropped as India look to play extra seamer in third T20



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nottingham

Yet to win a game in the ongoing tour of the UK, a desperate India will most certainly include an additional pacer at the expense of out-of-sync leg-spinner Ravi Bishnoi in the third T20 International against England here on Tuesday.

Under new skipper Shreyas Iyer, India have lost three out of their four games including a humiliating 0-2 series loss to Ireland.

Bishnoi, whose three back-foot no balls and a 29-run over cost India the second T20 International, had looked horribly out of rhythm during his wicketless spell that leaked 60 runs in four overs at

Manchester.

There were a lot of questions asked on whether conditions at Old Trafford warranted a third specialist spinner when Axar Patel and Varun Chakravarthy were already on board. At Trent Bridge, there is little chance that Bishnoi, who was even dropped by his franchise Rajasthan Royals in the last edition of the Indian Premier League, will be considered for this particular game.

It is expected that a pace bowler will come into the eleven and Prince Yadav, with his ability to move the ball in the air and off the surface looks a better candidate compared to Prasidh Krishna, whose natural back of the length deliveries are easy to hit in the T20 format. Arshdeep Singh got three wickets in the last game, including

a double in his opening over, but he would also agree that the 27 runs that England skipper Harry Brook took off him were also a big reason for the hosts chasing down the target of 191 with an over to spare.

While the third T20 International will be a day-night affair, the Trent Bridge surface promises to be a good one for batting where Vaibhav Sooryavanshi can enthrall his legion of fans along with the in-form Abhishek Sharma. Having played 90 per cent of their matches on flat decks for the past six months, including IPL, the Indian batting unit is also struggling to cope with extra bounce, some off the surface movement and also the variations used by someone like a Sam Curran.

Skipper Iyer, and one down Ishan Kishan have got a few runs but they will be first ones to put hands on their hearts and admit that they haven't exactly dominated the English attack.

Summer McIntosh breaks women's 200-m butterfly world record

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Montreal

Summer McIntosh broke the longest-standing individual women's swimming world record Sunday night, finishing the 200-meter butterfly in 2 minutes 1.65 seconds at the Canadian trials.

The 19-year-old McIntosh broke the mark of 2:01.81 set by China's Liu Zige in 2009 during what's known as the super-suit era. A three-time champion at the 2004 Paris Olympics,



McIntosh slammed her fists into the water in celebration while smiling ear-to-ear as the crowd erupted inside the Olympic pool.

McIntosh has long targeted the record, coming within 0.18 seconds with a time of 2:01.99 last year in the world championships.

'Bizarre to drop Samson but great to see Vaibhav debut'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Former batter Sanjay Manjrekar believes India's decision to drop Sanju Samson in the second T20 against England was a "bizarre" call even though it was "great" to see teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi finally make his debut.

The 15-year-old made a 10-ball 14 after becoming the youngest Indian to make his international debut sur-

passing Sachin Tendulkar, who was 16 when he first played for India back in 1989. India, however, lost the match on Saturday by four wickets to trail 0-1 in the five-match series after the opening game was washed out. Sooryavanshi's debut came at the expense of T20 World Cup hero Samson as he has struggled to get going on ongoing tour. Manjrekar said there was no need to leave Samson out for Sooryavanshi as both could have been accommodated.

Women's cricket is in golden era: ICC chairman Jay Shah

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ London

ICC Chairman Jay Shah hailed women's cricket as being in a "golden era" after Australia outclassed England to win their seventh ICC T20 World Cup title at Lord's, saying the tournament showed why the sport is "unmissable."

Australia restricted England to 150 after electing to bowl before chasing down the target in 17.1 overs, with Beth Mooney top-scoring with 64. Shah later presented the trophy to Australia captain Sophie Molineux.

"Congratulations to Cricket Australia on winning their seventh ICC Women's T20



World Cup title with another incredible campaign. Huge credit to England cricket too—fantastic runners-up but champions in spirit," Shah posted on Twitter. "This tournament reminded us why women's

cricket is unmissable—power, passion, and pure class on display from start to finish. Thank you to both teams and everyone who made this WC so special. Women's cricket is in a golden era," he added.

Hope and Greaves dig in to lift West Indies to 318-4 in 2nd test against Sri Lanka

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ North Sound (Antigua)

Shai Hope and Justin Greaves shared an unbroken partnership of 174 runs for the fifth wicket as the West Indies reached 318-4 in its first innings, in reply to Sri Lanka's 549-9 declared, at stumps Sunday on the third day of the second Test.

On a day of measured progress, only three wickets fell and 260 runs were added. Only 13 wickets have fallen in the first three days.

Hope was 86 not out and Greaves 85 not out at the close of play, approaching their fifth and third test centuries respectively. The pair also were closing in on their highest partnership of 196, achieved against New Zealand in Christchurch in December.



The West Indies lead the two-Test series after winning the first Test by an innings and 217 runs. With that in mind, the onus was on Sri Lanka to make the play on the third day but wickets were hard to come by on a

placid pitch at the Sir Vivian Richards Stadium. Only one wicket fell in the first session Sunday as John Campbell (72) and Kavem Hodge (31) put on 89 for the second wicket after West Indies resumed at 58-1.

'Bahutule should have rectified Bishnoi's run-up'



SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former India leg-spinner Laxman Sivaramakrishnan has questioned Team India's spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule for failing to correct Ravi Bishnoi's increasingly wide run-up, which resulted in repeated back-foot no-balls during India's four-wicket defeat to England in the second T20I. Bishnoi conceded 60 runs in four overs and cut the return crease three times, including twice in the 17th over that yielded 29 runs and swung the game decisively in England's favour.

"A spinner should not be bowling a no-ball. It's a crime. And for him to bowl a back-foot no-ball, cutting the return crease, is something that should have been noticed in the nets. Sairaj (Bahutule) should have first noticed his run-up and looked at whether he was overstepping or cutting the return crease. First thing you look at is bowling a legal delivery, and then bowling a legally good delivery," Sivaramakrishnan said. The former India leg-spinner said a spinner committing no-balls at the international level reflected a lack of proper guidance. (PTI)

WFI, IIS extend collaboration for 3 years until 2029

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Wrestling Federation of India has renewed its partnership with the Inspire Institute of Sport, the JSW Group-promoted Olympic high-performance training centre, for another three years until March 2029.

Under the renewed agreement, IIS will continue supporting WFI's national programme across the senior, junior and cadet levels, while integrating its high-performance expertise into national coaching camps and athlete development initiatives.

The collaboration will focus on world-class training support.

Gukesh leads long list of star players in Chennai Grand Masters from July 16

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

World Champion D Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi and former World Rapid Champion Nodirbek Abdosattorov are some of the leading players who will feature in the fourth edition of the Chennai Grand Masters, to be held here from July 16 to 22. The tournament, which carries a prize pool of ₹75 lakh, also offers valuable FIDE Circuit points as players continue their pursuit of qualification for the next Candidates Tournament. The tournament will also



see two-time Grand Chess Tour champion Alireza Firouzja, 2026 Bullet Chess Champion Nihal Sarin, former Candidates challenger Dmitry Andreikin, American GM Hans Niemann, and last year's Challengers champion Praneeth M in action.

"Every edition strengthens our resolve to build a tournament that the world's best players are proud to compete in while creating meaningful opportunities for Indian talent to test themselves against the very best," said Manu Gurtu, Tournament Director.

Grand Chess tour: Praggnanandhaa ends tied third, Gukesh sixth; Alireza wins

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Zagreb (Croatia)

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa bounced back with a decent effort on the final day to finish tied third in the Croatian leg of the Grand chess tour here on Monday. France's Firouzja Alireza bagged the top honours with 23.5 points. Praggnanandhaa shared the third spot with another Frenchman Maxime Vachier-Lagrave, logging 21.5 points.

The Indian star began the final day with a loss against Vincent Keymer but then did well to score 6 points out of the last eight games. His other loss came against compatriot D Gukesh but Praggnanandhaa's main victim was Alireza. After a splendid start in the blitz on the opening day when he scored



8 points out of a possible nine, Alireza had a rather forgettable final day and could only make 5 points, allowing Uzbek Nodirbek Abdosattorov to catch up with him in the overall standings on 23.5 points.

It led to a tie-break finale wherein the first two games ended in draws and after that the Frenchman drew with Abdosattorov in the Armageddon to be crowned the champion.

Coco Gauff's buzzer-beater reminds her of Kawhi's shot

ANDREW DAMPF ■ London

There's not usually a clock ticking down in tennis.

Yet for Coco Gauff at Wimbledon on Sunday, the All England Club's 11 pm curfew made it seem like there was.

And Gauff hit the winning shot at the buzzer.

Two minutes before 11, Gauff converted her first match point with a service winner out wide to reach the quarterfinals at the grass-court Grand Slam for the first time.

After beating Belinda Bencic 4-6, 6-3, 6-4, Gauff tapped her left wrist with the fingers on her right hand to acknowledge the timely ending.

Gauff said it "kind of reminded me of" Kawhi Leonard's shot for the Toronto Raptors in 2019 that bounced off the rim four times before becoming the first Game 7 buzzer-beater in NBA history. Because if Gauff hadn't ended it in that game, the match would have been suspended until Monday.



"I was looking at the clock the last service game," she said. "I was like, I got to hit some big serves and some big shots." And honestly, that match point, I was going for a serve and volley because I was like, 'I need to end the point.'

"That was probably the most dramatic finish. I've never had to race against time. Playing tennis we're used to not having a clock. But honestly, today I felt the pressure. Glad I didn't choose basketball." (AP)

Naomi Osaka overpowers Aryna Sabalenka to reach the Wimbledon quarterfinals

ANDREW DAMPF ■ London

When power meets power, getting in the first blow can sometimes be the key. In a matchup of two of the hardest hitters on tour, that was Naomi Osaka's strategy against top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka in the most highly-awaited matchup of Wimbledon so far this year.

Sabalenka had beaten Osaka in all three of their previous matches this year — including at the same stage of the French Open last month.

"On the clay courts I felt like she was pushing me back a lot. I just tried to do it to her first," Osaka said. The tactics worked, and Osaka outslugged Sabalenka 6-2, 7-6 (2) to reach the quarterfinals at the All England Club for the first time on Sunday.

Osaka's pace and flat ground-strokes overwhelmed Sabalenka.

"Obviously we're big ball strikers. It's not like I'm going to start running around the court trying to draw an error from her. I can only focus on my strengths," Osaka said.

"I just tried to serve really well, because it's grass. I also tried to get



the upper hand in the rallies first."

Osaka's power had an even bigger impact than usual as her balls flew through the air faster on the warmest day of the tournament so far: The temperature during the match reached 28 degrees Celsius (82 Fahrenheit).

"She overpowered me," Sabalenka said. "I felt like it was incredible level from her."

Besides Paris, Sabalenka also beat Osaka in Indian Wells,

California, and Madrid this year.

"That really sucked," Osaka said. "So I wanted to turn it (around)."

When it was over, Osaka performed a few fist pumps, let out a brief smile and then placed her racket over her head and spun around in delight to celebrate her first career win on Centre Court.

"It's been a long time since I've had so much fun on the court," Osaka said. "And to do it here, it really means a lot."

Djokovic breaks another Federer record at Wimbledon



MATTIAS KAREN ■ London

After all the records Novak Djokovic has broken, the latest one left him rather unimpressed — even though he surpassed his great rival Roger Federer.

Djokovic set a men's record for most match wins at Wimbledon after overcoming a surprisingly tough challenge from 132nd-ranked qualifier Roman Safiullin on Sunday to reach the quarterfinals.

The seven-time Wimbledon champion screamed out his frustrations at times - later referring to the outbursts as "meltdowns" — before winning 7-6 (6),

6-3, 3-6, 6-3 for his 106th match victory at the All England Club. That puts him one ahead of Federer atop the all-time list for men, although he still trails Martina Navratilova's 120 match wins.

That's clearly not the record he's after at Wimbledon, though. Not when he's also trying to match Federer's eight titles and become the first man or woman to win 25 major trophies.

"Not on my priority list," Djokovic said. "Didn't even know about it until after the last match win ... That's really quite insignificant to me at the moment." (AP)